

The Crisis of the Modern World

BY RENÉ GUÉNON

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CONTENTS

PREFACE	5
I. THE DARK AGE	15
II. THE OPPOSITION BETWEEN EAST AND WEST	36
III. KNOWLEDGE AND ACTION	53
IV. SACRED AND PROFANE SCIENCE	67
V. INDIVIDUALISM	87
VI. THE SOCIAL CHAOS	108
VII. A MATERIAL CIVILIZATION	126
VIII. WESTERN ENCROACHMENT	149
IX. SOME CONCLUSIONS	164

PREFACE

WHEN, SOME YEARS AGO, we wrote *East and West*, we believed that, upon the questions which formed the subject of that book, we had furnished all the indications then necessary, at least for the time being. Since that moment, events have hastened onward with an ever-increasing rapidity; and, without in the least compelling us to alter a single word of what we then affirmed, they render opportune certain complementary precisions and lead us to develop points of view upon which we had not thought it necessary at first to insist. These precisions impose themselves all the more inasmuch as we have seen, of late, some of the confusions that we had expressly endeavoured to dispel reassert themselves anew, and under a form sufficiently aggressive; while carefully abstaining from engaging in any controversy, we have judged it well to set matters in order once again. There are, in this domain, considerations, even of the most elementary kind, which appear so foreign to the immense majority of our contemporaries that, in order to make them understood, one must not weary of returning to them again and again, presenting them under their different aspects, and explaining more fully, as circumstances permit, whatever

may give rise to difficulties that it was not always possible to foresee at the outset.

The very title of the present volume calls for certain explanations which we must first provide, so that it may be clearly known in what sense we understand it and that no ambiguity may subsist on this point. That one may speak of a crisis of the modern world, taking the word "crisis" in its most ordinary acceptation, is something which many no longer doubt; and in this respect at least a rather notable change has occurred: under the pressure of events themselves, certain illusions begin to dissolve, and we for our part can only rejoice in this, for there is therein, despite all, a symptom not unfavourable, the sign of a possible rectification of the contemporary mentality, something that appears as a faint glimmer in the midst of the present chaos. Thus the belief in an indefinite "progress," which until quite recently was held as a sort of intangible and incontestable dogma, is no longer so generally admitted; some begin to perceive, more or less vaguely and confusedly, that Western civilization, instead of continuing always to develop in the same direction, might well one day reach a point of arrest, or even sink entirely in some cataclysm. Perhaps such persons do not clearly discern where the danger lies, and the chimerical or childish fears they sometimes manifest sufficiently prove the persistence of many errors in their minds; yet it is already something that they are aware there is a danger, even if they feel it more than they truly understand it, and that they come to conceive

that this civilization of which the moderns are so infatuated does not occupy a privileged place in the history of the world, that it may meet the same fate as so many others which have already disappeared in epochs more or less remote, and of which some have left behind them only the most meagre traces, vestiges scarcely perceptible or difficult to recognize.

If, then, it be said that the modern world is undergoing a crisis, what is most commonly meant thereby is that it has reached a critical point, or, in other words, that a transformation more or less profound is imminent, that a change of orientation must inevitably occur within a short time, whether willingly or by constraint, in a manner more or less abrupt, with or without catastrophe. This acceptance is perfectly legitimate and corresponds indeed to a part of what we ourselves think, but only to a part; for, as we see it, and from a more general standpoint, the whole of the modern epoch, taken in its entirety, represents for the world a period of crisis. It even seems that we are approaching the denouement, and this renders more perceptible today than ever the abnormal character of a state of things that has endured for several centuries, but whose consequences had not yet been so visible as they are now. It is also for this reason that events unfold with that accelerated rapidity to which we alluded at the outset; no doubt this may continue thus for some time yet, but not indefinitely; and even without being able to assign a precise

limit, one has the impression that it cannot endure very much longer.

Yet within the very word “crisis” are contained other significations that render it still more apt to express what we intend: its etymology indeed, often lost sight of in current usage, but to which it is fitting to return—as one must always do when one would restore to a term the plenitude of its proper sense and original value—this etymology, we say, makes it in part synonymous with “judgment” and with “discernment.” The phase that may truly be called “critical,” in whatever order of things, is that which leads immediately to a favourable or an unfavourable issue, that wherein a decision intervenes in one direction or the other; it is then, consequently, that it becomes possible to pronounce upon the results acquired, to weigh the “for” and the “against,” effecting a kind of discrimination among those results, some positive, others negative, and thus to see upon which side the balance definitively inclines. We have, assuredly, no pretension to establish in a complete manner such a discrimination, which would moreover be premature, since the crisis is not yet resolved and it is perhaps not even possible to say exactly when and how it will be so; the more so as it is always preferable to abstain from certain predictions that could not rest upon reasons clearly intelligible to all, and which, for that very cause, would risk being misinterpreted and adding to the confusion rather than remedying it. All that we can propose to ourselves, therefore, is to contribute, to a certain extent and so far as

the means at our disposal permit, to giving those who are capable of it a consciousness of some among the results that already seem firmly established, and thus to prepare, even if only in a very partial and rather indirect manner, the elements that must later serve for the future “judgment,” from which a new period in the history of terrestrial humanity will be opened.

Some of the expressions we have just employed will doubtless evoke, in the minds of certain readers, the idea of what is called the “Last Judgment,” and, in truth, not without reason; whether it be understood literally or symbolically, or in both ways at once—for these do not in reality exclude one another—matters little here, and this is neither the place nor the moment to explain ourselves fully on that point. In any case, this weighing of the “for” and the “against,” this discrimination of positive and negative results of which we spoke just now, may assuredly call to mind the division of the “elect” and the “damned” into two groups henceforth immutably fixed; even if there be here no more than an analogy, it must be acknowledged that it is at least a valid and well-founded analogy, in conformity with the very nature of things; and this in turn calls for some further explanations.

It is certainly not by chance that so many minds are today haunted by the idea of the “end of the world”; one may regret this in certain respects, for the extravagances to which this ill-understood idea gives rise, the “messianic” aberrations that result from it in various circles, all these

manifestations born of the mental disequilibrium of our age serve only to aggravate that same disequilibrium in proportions that are by no means negligible; yet it remains no less certain that there is here a fact of which one cannot dispense with taking account. The most convenient attitude, when confronted with things of this kind, is assuredly that which consists in dismissing them purely and simply without further examination, in treating them as errors or daydreams of no importance; we think, however, that even if they are indeed errors, it is better, while denouncing them as such, to seek the reasons that have provoked them and the portion of truth, more or less deformed, that they may nonetheless contain; for error, having in sum only a purely negative mode of existence, absolute error can be found nowhere and is but an empty word devoid of meaning. If matters be considered in this way, one perceives without difficulty that this preoccupation with the “end of the world” is closely linked to the state of general malaise in which we presently live: the obscure presentiment of something that is indeed near to its end, acting without control upon certain imaginations, naturally produces therein disordered representations, most often crudely materialized, which in their turn translate themselves outwardly in the extravagances to which we have just alluded. This explanation, moreover, is not an excuse in their favour; or at least, if one may excuse those who fall involuntarily into error because they are predisposed thereto by a mental state for which they are not responsible, this can

never be a reason for excusing the error itself. As for ourselves, assuredly no one will reproach us with excessive indulgence toward the “pseudo-religious” manifestations of the contemporary world, any more than toward modern errors in general; we are even aware that some would rather be tempted to reproach us with the contrary, and perhaps what we say here will enable them better to understand how we regard these things, striving always to place ourselves at the sole point of view that matters to us, that of impartial and disinterested truth.

Nor is this all: a merely “psychological” explanation of the idea of the “end of the world” and of its present manifestations, however just it may be within its own order, cannot in our eyes pass for fully sufficient; to stop there would be to allow oneself to be influenced by one of those modern illusions against which we raise ourselves on every occasion. Certain persons, we have said, feel confusedly the imminent end of something whose nature and scope they cannot precisely define; it must be admitted that they possess therein a perception very real, though vague and subject to false interpretations or to imaginative distortions, for, whatever that end may be, the crisis that must necessarily lead to it is sufficiently apparent, and a multitude of signs, unequivocal and easy to observe, all converge concordantly toward the same conclusion. This end is doubtless not the “end of the world” in the total sense that some would ascribe to it, but it is at least the end of a world; and if that which must end is Western civilization in its

present form, it is understandable that those who have grown accustomed to see nothing beyond it, to regard it as “civilization” without qualification, should readily believe that all will end with it, and that, if it should disappear, this would indeed be the “end of the world.”

We shall therefore say, in order to restore things to their just proportions, that it does indeed seem that we are approaching the end of a world, that is to say, the end of an epoch or of an historical cycle, which moreover may correspond with a cosmic cycle, according to what all traditional doctrines teach in this regard. There have already been in the past many events of this kind, and doubtless there will yet be others in the future; events of unequal importance, moreover, according as they terminate periods more or less extended and concern either the whole of terrestrial humanity or only one or another of its portions, a particular race or people. It is to be supposed, in the present state of the world, that the change which will intervene will have a very general scope, and that, whatever form it may assume, and which we do not intend to seek to define, it will affect more or less the entire earth. In any case, the laws that govern such events are applicable analogically at every degree; thus what is said of the “end of the world,” in as complete a sense as it is possible to conceive it—and which moreover ordinarily relates only to the terrestrial world—is still true, proportions being preserved, when it is simply a matter of the end of any world whatsoever in a much more restricted sense.

These preliminary observations will greatly aid in understanding the considerations that follow; we have already had occasion, in other works, to allude rather often to the “cyclical laws”; it might indeed be difficult to give of these laws a complete exposition in a form easily accessible to Western minds, yet at least it is necessary to possess some data on this subject if one would form a true idea of what the present epoch is and of what it exactly represents in the ensemble of the history of the world. It is for this reason that we shall begin by showing that the characters of this epoch are indeed those which traditional doctrines have always indicated for the cyclical period to which it corresponds; and this will also be to show that what is anomaly and disorder from a certain point of view is nonetheless an element necessary to a vaster order, an inevitable consequence of the laws that govern the development of every manifestation. Let us say at once, however, that this is not a reason to resign oneself to passively undergoing the trouble and obscurity that seem for the moment to triumph, for if it were so we should have only to keep silence; it is, on the contrary, a reason to labour, so far as one may, to prepare the exit from this “dark age,” of which many indications already permit one to foresee the end more or less near, if not altogether imminent. This also belongs to the order of things, for equilibrium is the result of the simultaneous action of two opposed tendencies; if one or the other could entirely cease to act, equilibrium would never again be restored and the world itself would vanish away; but such a supposition is

unrealizable, for the two terms of an opposition have meaning only through one another, and, whatever appearances may suggest, one may be assured that all partial and transitory disequilibria concur in the end toward the realization of total equilibrium.

-I- THE DARK AGE

THE HINDU DOCTRINE TEACHES that the duration of a human cycle, to which it gives the name of *Manvantara*, is divided into four ages, marking so many phases of a gradual obscuration of primordial spirituality; these are the same periods which the traditions of Western antiquity, on their side, designated as the ages of gold, silver, bronze, and iron. We are at present in the fourth age, the *Kali-Yuga* or “dark age,” and we have been so, it is said, for more than six thousand years already, that is to say, since a time far anterior to all those known to “classical” history. Since then, the truths that were once accessible to all men have become more and more hidden and difficult of access; those who possess them are ever fewer, and, although the treasure of “non-human” wisdom, anterior to all ages, can never be lost, it becomes enveloped in veils increasingly impenetrable, which conceal it from sight and beneath which it is extremely difficult to discover it. Hence it is that everywhere there is question, under diverse symbols, of something which has been lost, at least in appearance and in relation to the outward world, and which must be recovered by those who aspire to true knowledge; but it is also said that what is thus hidden will become visible again at the end of this

cycle, which will at the same time, by virtue of the continuity that binds all things together, be the beginning of a new cycle.

But, it will doubtless be asked, why must cyclical development be accomplished thus in a descending sense, passing from the superior to the inferior, which, as will readily be remarked, is the very negation of the idea of “progress” as the moderns understand it? It is because the development of every manifestation necessarily implies an ever greater distance from the principle from which it proceeds; setting forth from the highest point, it tends inevitably downward, and, like heavy bodies, it tends thither with a speed ever increasing, until it encounters at last a point of arrest. This descent might be characterized as a progressive materialization, for the expression of the principle is pure spirituality; we say the expression, and not the principle itself, for the latter cannot be designated by any of the terms that seem to indicate any opposition whatsoever, being beyond all oppositions. Moreover, words such as “spirit” and “matter,” which we borrow here for convenience from Western language, have for us hardly more than a symbolic value; in any case, they can truly apply to what is here in question only on condition that one set aside the special interpretations given them by modern philosophy, for whose eyes “spiritualism” and “materialism” are but two complementary forms that imply one another and are equally negligible for one who would rise above these contingent standpoints. Yet, moreover, it is not of

pure metaphysics that we propose to treat here, and that is why, without ever losing sight of the essential principles, we may, while taking the indispensable precautions to avoid all ambiguity, permit ourselves the use of terms which, though inadequate, appear capable of rendering things more easily intelligible, so far as this can be done without thereby distorting them.

What we have just said of the development of manifestation presents a view which, though exact in its ensemble, is nevertheless too simplified and schematic in that it might suggest that this development is effected in a straight line, according to a single direction and without oscillation of any kind; the reality is far more complex. Indeed, there is reason to envisage in all things, as we have already indicated earlier, two opposed tendencies, the one descending and the other ascending, or, if one prefers another mode of presentation, the one centrifugal and the other centripetal; and from the predominance of one or the other proceed two complementary phases of manifestation, the one of departure from the principle, the other of return toward the principle, which are often compared symbolically to the movements of the heart or to the two phases of respiration. Although these two phases are ordinarily described as successive, it must be conceived that in reality the two tendencies to which they correspond always act simultaneously, though in differing proportions; and it sometimes happens, at certain critical moments when the descending tendency seems on the point of prevailing

definitively in the general march of the world, that a special action intervenes to reinforce the contrary tendency, so as to restore a certain equilibrium at least relative, such as the conditions of the moment allow, and thus to effect a partial rectification, whereby the movement of descent may appear to be arrested or temporarily neutralized.¹

It is easy to understand that these traditional data, of which we must confine ourselves to sketching only a very summary outline, make possible conceptions wholly different from all the attempts at a “philosophy of history” to which the moderns devote themselves, and conceptions far more vast and profound. Yet we have no intention, for the moment, of going back to the origins of the present cycle, nor even more simply to the beginnings of the *Kali-Yuga*; our intention relates, at least directly, only to a much more limited domain, to the final phases of this same *Kali-Yuga*. Within each of the great periods of which we have spoken, one may in fact distinguish further secondary phases, constituting so many subdivisions; and, each part being in some manner analogous to the whole, these subdivisions reproduce, as it were on a reduced scale, the general course of the great cycle in which they are integrated. But here again, a complete inquiry into the modalities of application of this law to the various particular

¹ This relates to the function of “divine preservation,” which, in the Hindu tradition, is represented by Vishnu, and more specifically to the doctrine of Avatars or “descents” of the divine principle into the manifested world, which we cannot naturally consider developing here.

cases would carry us far beyond the framework we have set ourselves for the present study. We shall therefore mention only, in order to conclude these preliminary considerations, some of the last epochs particularly critical through which humanity has passed, those that fall within the period customarily called “historical,” because it is indeed the only one truly accessible to ordinary or “profane” history; and this will lead us quite naturally to that which must constitute the proper object of our study, since the last of these critical epochs is none other than that which forms what are called modern times.

There is a rather strange fact, which seems never to have been remarked as it deserves to be: namely, that the properly “historical” period, in the sense we have just indicated, goes back exactly to the sixth century before the Christian era, as though there were there, in time itself, a barrier which cannot be crossed by means of the methods of investigation at the disposal of ordinary researchers. From that epoch onward, one everywhere possesses a chronology sufficiently precise and well established; for all that is earlier, on the contrary, one generally obtains only a very vague approximation, and the dates proposed for the same events often vary by several centuries. Even for countries where there are more than scattered vestiges, as in Egypt for example, this is very striking; and what is perhaps more astonishing still is that, in an exceptional and privileged case such as that of China, which possesses, for epochs far more remote, annals dated by astronomical observations that

ought to leave no room for doubt, the moderns nonetheless qualify these epochs as “legendary,” as though there were here a domain in which they recognize for themselves no right to certainty and from which they forbid themselves to obtain it. The so-called “classical” antiquity is therefore, in truth, only a wholly relative antiquity, and even much nearer to modern times than to true antiquity, since it does not reach even halfway back into the *Kali-Yuga*, whose duration is itself, according to the Hindu doctrine, only the tenth part of that of the *Manvantara*; and from this one may sufficiently judge to what extent the moderns are justified in being proud of the range of their historical knowledge. All this, they would doubtless reply once more in their own justification, concerns only “legendary” periods, and that is why they believe they need not take account of them; but this reply is precisely the confession of their ignorance, and of an incomprehension which alone can explain their disdain for tradition; the specifically modern spirit is in fact, as we shall show later, nothing other than the anti-traditional spirit.

In the sixth century before the Christian era there occurred, whatever may have been the cause, considerable changes among almost all peoples; these changes moreover presented different characters according to the countries. In certain cases, it was a readaptation of the tradition to conditions other than those which had existed previously, a readaptation accomplished in a rigorously orthodox sense; this is what took place notably in China, where the doctrine,

originally constituted as a single whole, was then divided into two clearly distinct parts: Taoism, reserved to an elite and comprising pure metaphysics and the traditional sciences of a properly speculative order; Confucianism, common to all without distinction, and having for its domain practical applications, chiefly social. Among the Persians, it seems that there was likewise a readaptation of Mazdeism, for that epoch was that of the last Zoroaster.² In India, there arose at that time Buddhism, which, whatever may have been its original character,³ was destined, at least in certain of its branches, to end in a revolt against the

² It should be noted that the name Zoroaster actually designates not a particular person, but a function, both prophetic and legislative; there were several Zoroasters, who lived in very different eras; and it is even likely that this function had a collective character, like that of Vyasa in India, and likewise in Egypt, what was attributed to Thoth or Hermes represents the work of the entire priestly caste.

³ The question of Buddhism is, in reality, far from being as simple as this brief overview might suggest; and it is interesting to note that, while Hindus, from the point of view of their own tradition, have always condemned Buddhists, many of them nonetheless profess great respect for the Buddha himself, some even going so far as to see in him the ninth Avatar, while others identify him with Christ.

On the other hand, with regard to Buddhism as it is known today, it is essential to carefully distinguish between its two forms, Mahayana and Hinayana, or the “Great Vehicle” and the “Lesser Vehicle”; Generally speaking, Buddhism outside of India differs markedly from its original Indian form, which began to rapidly lose ground after the death of Ashoka and disappeared completely a few centuries later.

traditional spirit, going so far as the negation of all authority, even to a veritable anarchy, in the etymological sense of an “absence of principle,” both in the intellectual order and in the social order. What is rather curious is that in India one finds no monument going back beyond that epoch, and the orientalist, who would have everything begin with Buddhism and who greatly exaggerate its importance, have attempted to draw from this observation an argument in favor of their thesis; the explanation of the fact, however, is very simple: all the earlier constructions were of wood, and thus they have naturally disappeared without leaving any trace;⁴ yet it is nonetheless true that such a change in the mode of construction necessarily corresponds to a profound modification of the general conditions of existence of the people in whom it occurred.

As we draw nearer to the West, we see that the same epoch was, among the Jews, that of the Babylonian captivity; and what is perhaps one of the most astonishing facts to be noted is that a brief period of seventy years sufficed to make them lose even their script, so that they were afterwards compelled to reconstitute the Sacred Books in characters wholly other than those which had been in use until then. One might cite many other events belonging to

⁴ This case is not unique to India and is also found in the West; it is for precisely the same reason that no remains of Gallic cities are found, although their existence is undeniable, being attested by contemporary accounts; and, there too, modern historians have taken advantage of this absence of monuments to portray the Gauls as savages living in the forests.

approximately the same date; we shall merely note that this was for Rome the beginning of the properly “historical” period, succeeding the “legendary” epoch of the kings, and that it is also known, though somewhat vaguely, that important movements then took place among the Celtic peoples. But, without insisting further upon these, we shall come to what concerns Greece. There likewise the sixth century was the point of departure of the so-called “classical” civilization, the only one to which the moderns concede the character of being “historical,” while all that precedes it is sufficiently ill known to be treated as “legendary,” although recent archaeological discoveries no longer permit any doubt that there existed there, at least, a very real civilization. We have moreover some reason to think that this first Hellenic civilization was intellectually far more interesting than that which followed it, and that the relations between the two are not without offering some analogy with those existing between medieval Europe and modern Europe. It must, however, be remarked that the division was not so radical as in the latter case, for there was, at least in part, a readaptation effected within the traditional order, principally in the domain of the “mysteries”; and to this must be linked Pythagoreanism, which was above all, under a new form, a restoration of the earlier Orphism, and whose evident ties with the Delphic cult of the Hyperborean Apollo even permit the envisaging of a continuous and regular filiation with one of the most ancient traditions of humanity.

But, on the other hand, there soon appeared something for which there had hitherto been no example and which was destined thereafter to exercise a baneful influence over the whole Western world: we mean that special mode of thought which took and retained the name of "philosophy"; and this point is of sufficient importance for us to dwell upon it for a few moments.

The word "philosophy," taken in itself, may assuredly be understood in a wholly legitimate sense, which was doubtless its primitive meaning, especially if it be true, as is claimed, that Pythagoras first employed it: etymologically, it signifies nothing other than "love of wisdom"; it thus denotes first of all a prior disposition required in order to attain wisdom, and it may also designate, by a perfectly natural extension, the search which, springing from this very disposition, must lead to knowledge. It is therefore only a preliminary and preparatory stage, an approach to wisdom, a degree corresponding to a state inferior to it;⁵ the deviation that later occurred consisted in taking this transitory degree for the very end itself, in claiming to substitute "philosophy" for wisdom, which implies the forgetting or misrecognition of the true nature of the latter. Thus was born what we may call "profane" philosophy, that is to say, a pretended wisdom purely human and therefore of a simply rational order,

⁵ The relationship here is roughly the same as that which exists, in Taoist doctrine, between the state of the "endowed man" and that of the "transcendent man".

taking the place of the true traditional wisdom, suprarational and “non-human.”

Yet something of the latter still subsisted throughout antiquity; what proves this, first of all, is the persistence of the “mysteries,” whose essentially initiatic character cannot be contested, and it is also the fact that the teaching of the philosophers themselves most often possessed at once an “exoteric” side and an “esoteric” side, the latter allowing a connection with a higher point of view, which moreover manifests itself in a very clear manner, though perhaps incomplete in certain respects, a few centuries later among the Alexandrians. For “profane” philosophy to be definitively constituted as such, it was necessary that the “exoterism” alone should remain and that one should go so far as the pure and simple negation of all “esoterism”; this is precisely what the movement begun among the Greeks was destined to reach among the moderns. The tendencies which had already affirmed themselves among the former were then to be pushed to their most extreme consequences, and the excessive importance they had accorded to rational thought was to become still more accentuated, in order finally to issue in “rationalism,” a specifically modern attitude consisting no longer merely in ignoring, but in expressly denying all that belongs to the suprarational order. But let us not anticipate further, for we shall have to return to these consequences and observe their development in another part of our exposition.

In what has just been said, one thing is particularly to be retained from the point of view that concerns us: namely, that one must seek in “classical” antiquity some of the origins of the modern world; the latter is therefore not entirely wrong when it appeals to Greco-Latin civilization and claims to be its continuator. It must nevertheless be said that this is only a distant and somewhat unfaithful continuation, for there were, despite all, in that antiquity many things, in the intellectual and spiritual order, of which no equivalent can be found among the moderns; they represent, in any case, two quite different degrees in the progressive obscuration of true knowledge. One might moreover conceive that the decadence of ancient civilization could have led, in a gradual manner and without solution of continuity, to a state more or less similar to that which we see today; but in fact this was not so, and, in the interval, there occurred for the West another critical epoch which was at the same time one of those epochs of rectification to which we alluded above.

This epoch is that of the beginning and expansion of Christianity, coinciding on the one hand with the dispersion of the Jewish people, and on the other with the final phase of the Greco-Latin civilization; and we may pass more rapidly over these events, despite their importance, because they are more generally known than those of which we have hitherto spoken, and because their synchronism has been more readily observed, even by historians whose views remain the most superficial. Certain common features

between the ancient decline and the present age have also often been pointed out; and, without pressing the parallel too far, one must indeed recognize that there are some rather striking resemblances. Purely “profane” philosophy had gained ground: the appearance of scepticism on the one side, and the success of Stoic and Epicurean “moralism” on the other, sufficiently show to what extent intellectuality had been lowered. At the same time, the ancient sacred doctrines, which almost no one any longer understood, had, through that very incomprehension, degenerated into “paganism” in the true sense of the word; that is to say, they were no more than “superstitions,” things which, having lost their profound meaning, survive themselves only in wholly outward manifestations. There were attempts at reaction against this decadence: Hellenism itself sought to revive by means of elements borrowed from the Oriental doctrines with which it might come into contact; but this was no longer sufficient, the Greco-Latin civilization had to come to an end, and the rectification had to come from elsewhere and to be effected under an altogether different form. It was Christianity that accomplished this transformation; and let it be noted in passing that the comparison which may be established in certain respects between that time and our own is perhaps one of the determining elements of the disordered “messianism” that now makes itself felt. After the troubled period of the barbarian invasions, necessary to complete the destruction of the former state of things, a normal order was restored for

a duration of some centuries; this was the Middle Ages, so little understood by the moderns, who are incapable of comprehending its intellectuality, and for whom that epoch appears certainly far more strange and remote than “classical” antiquity.

The true Middle Ages, for us, extend from the reign of Charlemagne to the beginning of the fourteenth century; at that latter date begins a new decadence which, through diverse stages, was to grow ever more accentuated down to our own time. There lies the real point of departure of the modern crisis: it is the beginning of the disaggregation of “Christendom,” with which the Western civilization of the Middle Ages was essentially identified; it is, at the same time as the end of the feudal régime, which was rather closely bound up with that same “Christendom,” the origin of the constitution of the “nationalities.” One must therefore carry the modern epoch back nearly two centuries earlier than is usually done; the Renaissance and the Reformation are above all resultant phenomena, and they were rendered possible only by the prior decadence; but, far from being a rectification, they marked a fall much more profound, because they consummated the definitive rupture with the traditional spirit, the one in the domain of the sciences and the arts, the other in the religious domain itself, which was nevertheless that in which such a rupture might have seemed the most difficult to conceive.

What is called the Renaissance was in reality, as we have said elsewhere, the death of many things; under pretext

of returning to the Greco-Roman civilization, only that was taken from it which had been most outward, because that alone had been able to express itself clearly in written texts; and this incomplete restitution could in any case have only a highly artificial character, since it concerned forms which for centuries had ceased to live their true life. As for the traditional sciences of the Middle Ages, after having still shown some last manifestations about that time, they disappeared as completely as those of distant civilizations once annihilated by some cataclysm; and this time nothing was to come to replace them. Thenceforth there remained only “profane” philosophy and science; that is to say, the negation of true intellectuality, the limitation of knowledge to the lowest order, the empirical and analytic study of facts which are attached to no principle, dispersion in an indefinite multitude of insignificant details, the accumulation of unfounded hypotheses incessantly destroying one another, and of fragmentary views that can lead to nothing, save to those practical applications which constitute the sole effective superiority of modern civilization; a superiority little to be envied moreover, and which, in developing to the point of stifling every other concern, has given that civilization the purely material character which makes of it a veritable monstrosity.

What is altogether extraordinary is the rapidity with which the civilization of the Middle Ages fell into the most complete oblivion; the men of the seventeenth century had no longer the least notion of it, and the monuments that

still subsisted represented nothing to their eyes, neither in the intellectual order nor even in the aesthetic order; one may judge from this how profoundly the mentality had been changed in the interval. We shall not undertake here to seek the factors, certainly very complex, that concurred in this change, so radical that it seems difficult to admit that it could have come about spontaneously and without the intervention of a directing will whose exact nature necessarily remains rather enigmatic; there are, in this respect, some very strange circumstances, such as the vulgarization, at a determined moment, and presented as new discoveries, of things that had in reality been known for a very long time, but whose knowledge, by reason of certain inconveniences that risked outweighing their advantages, had not until then been diffused in the public domain.⁶ It is also highly improbable that the legend which made of the Middle Ages an epoch of “darkness,” ignorance, and barbarism could have arisen and accredited itself of its own accord, and that the veritable falsification of history to which the moderns have given themselves up was undertaken without any preconceived idea; but we shall not pursue the examination of this question further, for, in whatever manner this work may have been accomplished, it

⁶ We will cite only two examples, among the facts of this kind which were to have the most serious consequences: the alleged invention of printing, which the Chinese knew prior to the Christian era, and the “official” discovery of America, with which communications much more frequent than is thought had existed throughout the Middle Ages.

is, for the moment, the observation of the result that, in sum, matters to us most.

There is a word that was brought into honour at the Renaissance, and that by anticipation summed up the whole programme of modern civilization: that word is “humanism.” It was indeed a matter of reducing everything to purely human proportions, of abstracting from every principle of a superior order, and, one might say symbolically, of turning away from Heaven under pretext of conquering the earth; the Greeks, whose example it was claimed to follow, had never gone so far in this direction, even in the time of their greatest intellectual decadence, and at least utilitarian preoccupations had never with them passed into the foremost place, as was soon to occur among the moderns. “Humanism” was already a first form of what has since become contemporary “secularism”; and, in seeking to bring everything back to the measure of man, taken as an end in himself, men have ended by descending, stage by stage, to the level of what in him is most inferior, and by scarcely seeking anything further than the satisfaction of the needs inherent in the material side of his nature, a pursuit indeed illusory, for it creates ever more artificial needs than it can satisfy.

Will the modern world go all the way down this fatal slope, or will there be, as there was at the decline of the Greco-Latin world, a new rectification before it has reached the bottom of the abyss into which it is being drawn? It seems indeed that a halt midway is scarcely any longer

possible, and that, according to all the indications furnished by the traditional doctrines, we have truly entered the final phase of the *Kali-Yuga*, into the most sombre period of this “dark age,” into that state of dissolution from which there is no exit save by a cataclysm, for it is no longer a simple rectification that is then required, but a total renovation. Disorder and confusion reign in every domain; they have been carried to a point far beyond anything previously seen, and, having set out from the West, they now threaten to invade the whole world; we know well that their triumph can never be more than apparent and passing, yet at such a degree it appears as the sign of the gravest of all the crises that humanity has traversed in the course of its present cycle. Have we not arrived at that dread epoch foretold by the sacred books of India, “when the castes shall be confounded, when even the family shall no longer exist”? It suffices to look about one to be convinced that this state is indeed that of the present world, and to observe everywhere that profound decadence which the Gospel calls “the abomination of desolation.” One must not dissemble the gravity of the situation; it must be envisaged as it is, with no “optimism,” but also with no “pessimism,” since, as we said earlier, the end of the old world will also be the beginning of a new.

Now a question presents itself: what is the *raison d’être* of a period such as that in which we live? For, abnormal as present conditions may be when considered in themselves, they must nevertheless enter into the general

order of things, into that order which, according to an extreme-Oriental formula, is made of the sum of all disorders; this epoch, painful and troubled though it be, must also, like all the others, have its marked place in the ensemble of human development, and moreover the very fact that it was foreseen by the traditional doctrines is in this respect a sufficient indication. What we have said of the general course of a cycle of manifestation, proceeding in the direction of a progressive materialization, immediately gives the explanation of such a state, and shows clearly that what is abnormal and disordered from a certain particular point of view is nevertheless only the consequence of a law relating to a superior or more extended point of view. We shall add, without insisting upon it, that, like every change of state, the passage from one cycle to another can be accomplished only in obscurity; here again is a law of great importance and of manifold application, but whose somewhat detailed exposition would, for that very reason, carry us much too far.⁷

Nor is this all: the modern epoch must necessarily correspond to the development of certain of the possibilities which, from the origin, were included within the

⁷ This law was represented, in the Eleusinian Mysteries, by the symbolism of the grain of wheat; the alchemists depicted it by "putrefaction" and by the color black which marks the beginning of the "Great Work"; what Christian mystics call the "dark night of the soul" is simply its application to the spiritual development of the being who rises to higher states; and it would be easy to point out many other parallels

potentiality of the present cycle; and, however inferior the rank occupied by these possibilities in the hierarchy of the whole, they were none the less, like the others, destined to be called to manifestation according to the order assigned to them. In this respect, what, according to tradition, characterizes the ultimate phase of the cycle is, one might say, the exploitation of all that had been neglected or rejected during the preceding phases; and this, indeed, is precisely what we may observe in modern civilization, which in a sense lives only by what earlier civilizations had refused. To perceive this, one need only consider how the representatives of those civilizations that have endured until now in the Oriental world estimate the Western sciences and their industrial applications. These inferior knowledges, so vain in the eyes of one who possesses knowledge of another order, had nevertheless to be “realized,” and they could be so only at a stage where true intellectuality would have disappeared; these researches of an exclusively practical scope, in the narrowest sense of that word, had to be carried out, yet they could be so only at the extreme opposite of primordial spirituality, by men sunk in matter to the point of conceiving nothing beyond it, and becoming the more enslaved to that matter in proportion as they would make use of it, which leads them to an ever-increasing agitation, without rule and without end, to dispersion in pure multiplicity, and finally to dissolution.

Such, sketched in its broad lines and reduced to the essential, is the true explanation of the modern world; but

let it be declared very clearly that this explanation cannot in any way be taken for a justification. An inevitable misfortune is none the less a misfortune; and even if from evil a good must emerge, that does not remove from the evil its character; we employ here, moreover, the terms “good” and “evil” only in order to make ourselves more readily understood, and apart from any specifically “moral” intention. Partial disorders cannot but be, because they are necessary elements of the total order; yet, despite this, an epoch of disorder is, in itself, something comparable to a monstrosity, which, while being the consequence of certain natural laws, is nonetheless a deviation and a kind of error, or to a cataclysm, which, though resulting from the normal course of things, is still, when considered in isolation, an upheaval and an anomaly. Modern civilization, like all things, has of necessity its *raison d’être*, and, if it is indeed that which terminates a cycle, one may say that it is what it must be, that it comes in its time and place; but it must none the less be judged according to the evangelical word too often ill understood: “It must needs be that offences come; but woe to that man by whom the offence cometh!”

-II- THE OPPOSITION BETWEEN EAST AND WEST

ONE OF THE PARTICULAR characteristics of the modern world is the division that may be observed therein between East and West; and, although we have already treated this question in a more special manner, it is necessary to return to it here in order to determine certain of its aspects more precisely and to dissipate some misunderstandings. The truth is that there have always existed diverse and multiple civilizations, each of which developed in a manner proper to itself and in a direction conformable to the aptitudes of such a people or such a race; but distinction does not mean opposition, and there may be a kind of equivalence between civilizations of very different forms, provided they all rest upon the same fundamental principles, of which they represent only applications conditioned by varying circumstances. Such is the case with all the civilizations that we may call normal, or again traditional; between them there is no essential opposition, and the divergences, if there be any, are merely outward and superficial. On the contrary, a civilization that recognizes no superior principle, that is in reality founded only upon a negation of principles, is thereby deprived of every means of understanding with the

others, for such understanding, if it is to be truly deep and effective, can be established only from above, that is to say precisely by that which this abnormal and deviated civilization lacks. In the present state of the world, we therefore have, on the one side, all the civilizations that have remained faithful to the traditional spirit, and these are the Eastern civilizations; and, on the other, a civilization properly anti-traditional, which is the modern Western civilization.

Yet some have gone so far as to contest that the very division of humanity into East and West corresponds to any reality; but, at least for the present epoch, this cannot seriously be doubted. First of all, that there exists a Western civilization, common to Europe and America, is a fact upon which everyone must agree, whatever judgment may be formed concerning the value of that civilization. For the East, matters are less simple, because there exist in fact not one but several Eastern civilizations; but it suffices that they possess certain common traits, those which characterize what we have called a traditional civilization, and that these same traits are not found in Western civilization, for the distinction, and even the opposition, of East and West to be fully justified. And this is indeed the case, and the traditional character is in effect common to all the Eastern civilizations, for which we shall recall, in order to fix ideas more clearly, the general division we adopted earlier, and which, though perhaps somewhat too simplified if one wished to enter into detail, is nonetheless exact so long as one keeps to the broad

lines: the Far East, represented essentially by the Chinese civilization; the Middle East, by the Hindu civilization; the Near East, by the Islamic civilization. It should be added that the last of these ought, in many respects, rather to be regarded as intermediate between East and West, and that many of its characteristics bring it especially close to what Western civilization itself was in the Middle Ages; yet, if it be considered in relation to the modern West, one must recognize that it stands opposed to it in the same manner as the properly Eastern civilizations, with which it must therefore be associated from this point of view. This is what it is essential to insist upon: the opposition of East and West had no reason for being so long as there were also in the West traditional civilizations; it therefore has meaning only if one is speaking specifically of the modern West, for this opposition is far more that of two spirits than that of two geographical entities more or less clearly defined. At certain epochs, the nearest to us being the Middle Ages, the Western spirit resembled, in its most important aspects, what the Eastern spirit still is today, far more than it resembles what it has itself become in modern times; Western civilization was then comparable to the Eastern civilizations in the same way that these are comparable among themselves. Over the last few centuries there has taken place a considerable change, far more grave than all the deviations that had been able to manifest themselves previously in periods of decadence, since it goes so far as to a veritable reversal in the direction given to human activity;

and it is in the Western world alone that this change has had its origin. Consequently, when we speak of the Western spirit, referring to what exists at present, what must be understood thereby is nothing other than the modern spirit; and, since the other spirit has been maintained only in the East, we may, always in relation to present conditions, call it the Eastern spirit. These two terms, in sum, express nothing other than a situation of fact; and, if it appears clearly that one of the two spirits in presence is effectively Western, because its appearance belongs to recent history, we intend to prejudge nothing as to the provenance of the other, which was formerly common to East and West, and whose origin, in truth, must be confounded with that of humanity itself, since it is the spirit that might be called normal, if only because it inspired all the civilizations that we know more or less completely, with the exception of a single one, which is the modern Western civilization.

Some, who doubtless had not taken the trouble to read our books, have thought fit to reproach us with having said that all traditional doctrines had an Eastern origin, that Western antiquity itself, at all periods, had always received its traditions from the East; we have never written anything of the kind, nor even anything that could suggest such an opinion, for the simple reason that we know very well that it is false. It is in fact precisely the traditional data that clearly oppose such an assertion: everywhere one finds the formal affirmation that the primordial tradition of the present cycle came from the hyperborean regions; there were afterwards

several secondary currents, corresponding to diverse periods, and one of the most important of these, at least among those whose vestiges are still discernible, went incontestably from the West toward the East. But all this relates to epochs exceedingly remote, to those that are commonly called “prehistoric,” and this is not what we have in view; what we say is, first, that for a very long time now the deposit of the primordial tradition has been transferred to the East, and that it is there that are found at present the doctrinal forms that issue most directly from it; and next, that in the present state of things the true traditional spirit, with all that it implies, has no longer any authentic representatives except in the East.

To complete this clarification, we must also explain ourselves, at least briefly, concerning certain ideas of a restoration of a “Western tradition” which have arisen in various contemporary circles. Their sole interest, at bottom, lies in showing that a few minds are no longer satisfied with the modern negation, that they feel the need of something other than what our age offers them, and that they glimpse the possibility of a return to tradition, under one form or another, as the only means of emerging from the present crisis. Unfortunately, “traditionalism” is by no means the same thing as the true traditional spirit; it may be, and in fact very often is, no more than a simple tendency, a more or less vague aspiration, which presupposes no real knowledge; and, amid the mental disarray of our time, this aspiration gives rise above all—one must say it plainly—to fanciful and

chimerical conceptions devoid of any serious foundation. Finding no authentic tradition upon which they may rely, some go so far as to imagine pseudo-traditions which have never existed, and which lack principles no less than that which they would replace; all modern disorder is reflected in these constructions, and, whatever the intentions of their authors, the only result they obtain is to add a new contribution to the general disequilibrium. We shall mention only for the record, in this connection, the alleged “Western tradition” fabricated by certain occultists out of the most disparate elements, and intended above all to compete with an equally imaginary “Eastern tradition,” that of the theosophists. We have spoken sufficiently of such things elsewhere, and we prefer to proceed at once to the examination of certain other theories which may seem more worthy of attention, because one finds in them at least the desire to appeal to traditions that have had an effective existence.

We alluded just now to the traditional current issuing from the Western regions; the accounts of the ancients concerning Atlantis indicate its origin. After the disappearance of that continent, which is the last of the great cataclysms that have occurred in the past, it seems beyond doubt that remnants of its tradition were transported to diverse regions, where they mingled with other pre-existing traditions, principally with branches of the great Hyperborean tradition; and it is very possible that the doctrines of the Celts in particular were one of the

products of this fusion. We are far from contesting these things; but let it be well considered that the properly “Atlantean” form disappeared thousands of years ago, together with the civilization to which it belonged, and whose destruction can only have followed upon a deviation perhaps comparable, in certain respects, to that which we observe today, though with the notable difference that humanity had not yet then entered the *Kali-Yuga*. It must also be borne in mind that this tradition corresponded only to a secondary period of our cycle, and that it would be a grave error to identify it with the primordial tradition from which all others proceed, and which alone endures from beginning to end. It would be out of place to set forth here all the data that justify these affirmations; we shall retain only the conclusion, which is the impossibility, at present, of reviving an “Atlantean” tradition, or even of attaching oneself to it more or less directly. There is, moreover, much fantasy in attempts of this sort. It may nonetheless be of interest to seek the origin of the elements encountered in later traditions, provided this be done with all the precautions necessary to guard against certain illusions; but such researches can in no case result in the resurrection of a tradition that would be adapted to none of the present conditions of our world.

There are others who would attach themselves to “Celticism,” and, because they thus appeal to something less remote from us, it may seem that what they propose is less unrealizable; yet where today will they find “Celticism” in a

pure state, and still endowed with sufficient vitality to furnish a point of support? We are not speaking of archaeological or merely “literary” reconstructions, of which there have been a few; it is of something altogether different that we speak. That very recognizable and still usable Celtic elements have reached us through various intermediaries is true; but these elements are very far from representing the entirety of a tradition; and, what is surprising, that tradition, in the very countries where it once lived, is now more completely ignored than those of many civilizations that were always foreign to those same lands. Is there not in this something that should give pause, at least to those who are not wholly dominated by a preconceived idea? We shall say more: in all such cases, where one deals with vestiges left by vanished civilizations, it is possible truly to understand them only by comparison with what is similar in traditional civilizations that are still living; and the same may be said even of the Middle Ages themselves, where one encounters so many things whose significance is lost to modern Westerners. This contact with traditions whose spirit still subsists is in fact the only means of revivifying what is still capable of revival; and therein, as we have often indicated, lies one of the greatest services that the East can render to the West. We do not deny the survival of a certain “Celtic spirit,” which may still manifest under diverse forms, as it has already done at various epochs; but when we are assured that there still exist spiritual centres preserving integrally the Druidic tradition, we await that proof be furnished, and,

until further notice, this appears to us highly doubtful, if not altogether improbable.

The truth is that the surviving Celtic elements were for the most part assimilated, in the Middle Ages, by Christianity; the legend of the Holy Grail, with all that is connected with it, is in this respect a particularly probative and significant example. We think moreover that a Western tradition, if it were to succeed in reconstituting itself, would necessarily assume an outward religious form, in the strictest sense of the word, and that this form could only be Christian; for, on the one hand, the other possible forms have for too long been foreign to the Western mentality, and, on the other hand, it is in Christianity alone—let us say more precisely, in Catholicism—that there are found in the West the surviving remnants of the traditional spirit. Any “traditionalist” attempt that fails to take account of this fact is inevitably doomed to failure, because it lacks a basis; it is too evident that one can rely only upon what exists effectively, and that, where continuity is lacking, there can be only artificial reconstructions, which cannot be viable. If it be objected that Christianity itself, in our time, is scarcely any longer truly understood in its profound sense, we shall reply that it has at least preserved, in its very form, all that is necessary to furnish the basis in question. The least chimerical attempt—indeed the only one that does not encounter immediate impossibilities—would therefore be that which aimed at restoring something comparable to what existed in the Middle Ages, with the differences

required by the modification of circumstances; and, for all that is entirely lost in the West, it would be fitting to appeal to the traditions that have been preserved integrally, as we indicated just now, and then to accomplish a work of adaptation which could be only the task of a strongly constituted intellectual elite. All this we have already said; but it is well to insist upon it once more, because too many inconsistent reveries are at present given free rein, and also because it must be understood that, if the Eastern traditions, in their own forms, may certainly be assimilated by an elite which, by definition in some sort, must be beyond all forms, they will doubtless never be so—save by unforeseen transformations—by the generality of Westerners, for whom they were not made.

If a Western elite succeeds in forming itself, the true knowledge of the Eastern doctrines, for the reason we have just indicated, will be indispensable to it in order to fulfil its function; but those who will have only to receive the benefit of its work, and who will be the greater number, may very well have no awareness of these things, and the influence they receive—so to speak without suspecting it, and in any case by means that will entirely escape them—will be none the less real nor the less effective. We have never said otherwise; but we have thought it necessary to repeat it here as clearly as possible, because, if we must expect not always to be fully understood by all, we wish at least that intentions not ours be not attributed to us.

But let us now set aside all anticipations, since it is the present state of things that must chiefly occupy us, and return for a moment to the ideas of restoring a “Western tradition,” such as we can observe them around us. A single remark would suffice to show that these ideas are not “in order,” if one may so express it: namely, that they are almost always conceived in a spirit of hostility, more or less avowed, toward the East. Even those who would rely upon Christianity are sometimes animated by this spirit; they seem above all to seek to discover oppositions which in reality are wholly nonexistent; thus we have heard it asserted, absurdly, that, if the same things are found both in Christianity and in the Eastern doctrines, and expressed on either side under a nearly identical form, they nevertheless do not have the same meaning in the two cases, but even a contrary meaning. Those who advance such affirmations thereby prove that, whatever their pretensions, they have not gone very far in the understanding of traditional doctrines, since they have not glimpsed the fundamental identity that is concealed beneath all differences of outward form, and that, even where this identity becomes altogether apparent, they persist in failing to recognize it. Accordingly, they envisage Christianity itself only in a wholly external manner, which cannot correspond to the notion of a true traditional doctrine offering, in all orders, a complete synthesis; it is the principle that they lack, whereby they are affected, far more than they can suppose, by that modern spirit against which they would nevertheless react; and,

when they happen to employ the word “tradition,” they certainly do not take it in the same sense as we.

In the mental confusion that characterizes our age, this same word “tradition” has come to be applied indiscriminately to all manner of things, often quite insignificant, such as mere customs devoid of any real import and sometimes of wholly recent origin; elsewhere we have noted an abuse of the same kind in respect of the word “religion.” One must be wary of such deviations of language, which translate a sort of degeneration of the corresponding ideas; and it is not because someone entitles himself a “traditionalist” that it is certain he knows, even imperfectly, what tradition is in the true sense of the word. For our part, we absolutely refuse to give this name to anything that is of purely human order; it is not inopportune to declare this expressly when one encounters at every moment, for example, such an expression as “traditional philosophy.” A philosophy, even if it be truly all that it can be, has no right to this title, because it stands entirely within the rational order, even if it does not deny what surpasses it, and because it is only a construction erected by human individuals, without revelation or inspiration of any kind, or, to sum up all this in a single word, because it is something essentially profane. Moreover, despite all the illusions in which some seem to take complacency, it is certainly not a wholly “bookish” science that can suffice to rectify the mentality of a race and an epoch; for this there is required something other than

philosophical speculation, which, even in the most favorable case, is condemned by its very nature to remain wholly external and far more verbal than real. To restore the lost tradition, to revivify it truly, there is required the contact of the living traditional spirit, and, as we have already said, it is only in the East that this spirit is still fully alive; it is none the less true that this itself presupposes above all, in the West, an aspiration toward a return to that traditional spirit, though this can scarcely be more than a simple aspiration. The few movements of “anti-modern” reaction, moreover in our view very incomplete, that have appeared hitherto can only confirm us in this conviction; for all this, though doubtless excellent in its negative and critical part, remains far removed from a restoration of true intellectuality and develops only within the limits of a rather restricted mental horizon. It is nonetheless something, in that it is the sign of a state of mind of which one would have had great difficulty in finding the slightest trace a few years ago; if all Westerners are no longer unanimous in contenting themselves with the exclusively material development of modern civilization, this is perhaps a sign that, for them, all hope of salvation is not yet entirely lost.

Be that as it may, if one supposes that the West, in some manner, should return to its tradition, its opposition to the East would thereby be resolved and would cease to exist, since it has arisen only from the Western deviation and is in reality nothing but the opposition of the traditional spirit to the anti-traditional spirit. Thus, contrary to what

those to whom we alluded a moment ago suppose, the return to tradition would have, among its first results, that of rendering an understanding with the East immediately possible, as it is between all civilizations that possess comparable or equivalent elements, and between those alone; for it is these elements that constitute the sole ground upon which such an understanding can be validly effected. The true traditional spirit, under whatever form it be clothed, is everywhere and always the same in its essence; the diverse forms, specially adapted to such or such mental conditions, to such or such circumstances of time and place, are only expressions of one and the same truth; but one must be able to place oneself in the order of pure intellectuality in order to discover this fundamental unity beneath their apparent multiplicity. Moreover, it is in this intellectual order that the principles reside upon which all the rest normally depends as consequences or applications more or less remote; it is therefore upon these principles that one must agree before all else, if there is to be a truly profound understanding, since therein lies all that is essential; and, once they are really understood, agreement comes of itself. It must indeed be observed that the knowledge of principles, which is knowledge par excellence, metaphysical knowledge in the true sense of the word, is universal like the principles themselves, and therefore entirely disengaged from all individual contingencies, which, on the contrary, necessarily intervene as soon as one comes to applications; thus this purely intellectual domain is

the only one in which there is no need for an effort of adaptation between different mentalities. Furthermore, when a work of this order has been accomplished, it remains only to develop its results in order that agreement in all other domains be likewise realized, since, as we have just said, it is upon this that all depends directly or indirectly; whereas agreement obtained in a particular domain, outside principles, will always be eminently unstable and precarious, and much more akin to a diplomatic arrangement than to a true understanding. This is why, we insist once more, such an understanding can be effected only from above and not from below, and this must be understood in a double sense: one must begin from what is highest, that is to say from the principles, in order to descend gradually to the various orders of application while always rigorously observing the hierarchical dependence that exists between them; and this work, by its very character, can be only that of an elite, taking this word in its truest and most complete acceptance: it is of an intellectual elite that we speak exclusively, and, in our eyes, there can be no other, all external social distinctions being of no importance from the point of view at which we place ourselves.

These few considerations may already make it understood what is lacking to modern Western civilization, not only as regards the possibility of an effective rapprochement with the Eastern civilizations, but also in itself, if it is to be a normal and complete civilization; in truth, moreover, the two questions are so closely bound that

they form but one, and we have just given the reasons why it is so. We shall now have to show more fully wherein consists the anti-traditional spirit, which is properly the modern spirit, and what are the consequences it bears within itself, consequences which we see unfolding with an implacable logic in present events; but, before coming to this, one final reflection still imposes itself. It is not to be “anti-Western,” if one may employ this word, to be resolutely “anti-modern,” since on the contrary it is to make the only effort that is valid for attempting to save the West from its own disorder; and, on the other hand, no Oriental faithful to his own tradition can envisage things otherwise than we ourselves do. There are certainly far fewer adversaries of the West as such, which moreover would have little meaning, than of the West insofar as it identifies itself with modern civilization. Some speak today of a “defence of the West,” which is truly singular, when, as we shall see later, it is this very West that threatens to submerge everything and to draw the whole of humanity into the vortex of its disordered activity; singular, we say, and entirely unjustified, if they mean, as indeed it seems despite certain reservations, that this defence should be directed against the East, for the true East thinks neither of attacking nor of dominating anyone; it asks nothing more than its independence and its tranquillity, which, it will be admitted, is sufficiently legitimate. The truth, however, is that the West does indeed have great need to be defended, but solely against itself, against its own tendencies which, if carried to their limit, will inevitably lead it to ruin and

destruction; it is therefore “reform of the West” that one ought to say, and this reform, if it were what it must be, that is to say a true traditional restoration, would have as its entirely natural consequence a rapprochement with the East. For our part, we ask only to contribute at once, in the measure of our means, to this reform and to this rapprochement, if indeed there is still time, and if such a result can be obtained before the final catastrophe toward which modern civilization advances with great strides; but even if it were already too late to avoid this catastrophe, the work accomplished with this intention would not be useless, for it would in any case serve to prepare, however remotely, that “discrimination” of which we spoke at the beginning, and thus to ensure the conservation of the elements that must escape the shipwreck of the present world in order to become the germs of the world to come.

-III- KNOWLEDGE AND ACTION

WE SHALL NOW CONSIDER, in a more particular manner, one of the principal aspects of the opposition that exists at present between the Oriental spirit and the Western spirit, and which is, more generally, that of the traditional spirit and the anti-traditional spirit, as we have explained. From a certain point of view, which is moreover one of the most fundamental, this opposition appears as that of contemplation and action, or, to speak more exactly, as bearing upon the respective places that should be assigned to each of these two terms. These may, in their relation, be envisaged in several different ways: are they truly two contraries, as is most often supposed, or are they rather two complements, or again is there in reality between them a relation, not of coordination, but of subordination? Such are the different aspects of the question, and these aspects correspond to as many points of view, moreover of very unequal importance, though each can be justified in certain respects and corresponds to a certain order of reality.

First of all, the most superficial and most external point of view is that which consists in opposing contemplation and action purely and simply to one another as contraries in the strict sense of the word. The opposition

does indeed exist in appearances, this is incontestable; and yet, if it were absolutely irreducible, there would be a complete incompatibility between contemplation and action, which thus could never be found united. In fact, however, this is not so; there is not, at least in normal cases, any people, nor perhaps even any individual, who can be exclusively contemplative or exclusively active. What is true is that here there are two tendencies of which one or the other almost necessarily predominates, so that the development of one seems to be effected at the expense of the other, for the simple reason that human activity, understood in its most general sense, cannot be exercised equally and at once in all domains and in all directions. This is what gives the appearance of an opposition; but there must be a possible conciliation between these contraries, or so-called contraries; and moreover the same could be said of all contraries, which cease to be such as soon as, in order to envisage them, one rises above a certain level, that at which their opposition has all its reality. Wherever there is opposition or contrast, there is thereby disharmony or disequilibrium, that is to say something which, as we have already sufficiently indicated, can exist only from a relative, particular, and limited point of view.

In considering contemplation and action as complementary, one places oneself therefore at a point of view already more profound and more true than the preceding, because the opposition is there reconciled and resolved, these two terms balancing one another, as it were.

It would then seem to be a question of two equally necessary elements, which complete and support one another, and which constitute the double activity, inward and outward, of one and the same being, whether it be each man taken individually or humanity envisaged collectively. This conception is assuredly more harmonious and more satisfying than the first; nevertheless, if one were to adhere to it exclusively, one would be tempted, by virtue of the correlation thus established, to place contemplation and action upon the same plane, so that there would only be to strive to keep the balance as equal as possible between them, without ever raising the question of any superiority of one over the other; and what clearly shows that such a point of view is still insufficient is that this question of superiority is in fact raised and has always been raised, whatever be the sense in which one has wished to resolve it.

The question that matters in this respect, moreover, is not that of a predominance in fact, which is, in the last analysis, a matter of temperament or of race, but that of what might be called a predominance in right; and the two things are linked only up to a certain point. Doubtless, the recognition of the superiority of one of the two tendencies will incite one to develop it as much as possible in preference to the other; but, in application, it remains no less true that the place held by contemplation and action in the whole of the life of a man or of a people will always result in large part from its own nature, for one must in this take account of the particular possibilities of each. It is

manifest that the aptitude for contemplation is more widespread and more generally developed among the Orientals; there is probably no country where it is so much so as in India, and this is why the latter may be considered as representing par excellence what we have called the Oriental spirit. On the other hand, it is incontestable that, in a general way, the aptitude for action, or the tendency that results from this aptitude, is that which predominates among the Western peoples, as regards the great majority of individuals, and that, even if this tendency were not exaggerated and deviated as it is at present, it would nevertheless subsist, so that contemplation could never there be more than the affair of a much more restricted elite; this is why it is willingly said in India that, if the West were to return to a normal state and possess a regular social organization, one would doubtless find there many *Kshatriyas*, but few *Brahmans*.⁸ This would nevertheless suffice, if the intellectual elite were effectively constituted and if its supremacy were recognized, for everything to return to order; for spiritual power is in no wise based upon number, whose law is that of matter. And, let it be well noted, in antiquity and above all in the Middle Ages, the natural disposition toward action existing among the

⁸ Contemplation and action, in fact, are respectively the proper functions of the first two castes, that of the *Brahmins* and that of the *Kshatriyas*; thus their relationship is at the same time that of spiritual authority and temporal power; but we do not intend to consider this aspect of the question specifically here, as it deserves to be treated separately.

Westerners did not for all that prevent them from recognizing the superiority of contemplation, that is to say of pure intelligence; why is it otherwise in the modern epoch? Is it because the Westerners, by developing their faculties of action beyond measure, have ended by losing their intellectuality, and, in order to console themselves for this, have invented theories that place action above everything and even go, like “pragmatism,” so far as to deny that there exists anything of value outside it, or is it, on the contrary, this manner of seeing which, having first prevailed, has brought about the intellectual atrophy that we observe today? In both hypotheses, and also in the quite probable case where the truth would be found in a combination of the two, the results are exactly the same; at the point to which things have now come, it is high time to react, and it is here, let us say it once more, that the East can come to the aid of the West, if only the latter be willing, not in order to impose upon it conceptions foreign to it, as some seem to fear, but indeed to help it recover its own tradition, the sense of which it has lost.

One might say that the antithesis between East and West, in the present state of things, consists in this: that the East maintains the superiority of contemplation over action, whereas the modern West, on the contrary, affirms the superiority of action over contemplation. Here it is no longer, as when one spoke merely of opposition or of complementarity, a relation of coordination between the two terms in presence; it is no longer, we say, a question of

points of view each of which may have its reason for being and be accepted at least as the expression of a certain relative truth. A relation of subordination, by its very nature, being irreversible, the two conceptions are truly contradictory and therefore mutually exclusive, so that, once it be admitted that there is in fact subordination, one is true and the other false.

Before penetrating to the very root of the question, let us observe this further: whereas the spirit that has been maintained in the East is truly of all times, as we have already said, the other spirit has appeared only in a very recent epoch, which, apart from every other consideration, may already suggest that it is something abnormal. This impression is confirmed by the very excess into which the modern Western spirit falls in following its own tendency; not content to proclaim on every occasion the superiority of action, it has come to make of it an exclusive preoccupation and to deny all value to contemplation, whose true nature it in any case wholly ignores or misconceives. The Eastern doctrines, on the contrary, while affirming as clearly as possible the superiority and even the transcendence of contemplation in relation to action, none the less accord to the latter its legitimate place and readily recognize all its importance within the order of human contingencies.⁹

⁹ Those who might doubt the very real, albeit relative, importance that traditional Eastern doctrines, and especially those of India, give to action, need only refer to the *Bhagavad-Gita* to be convinced of it, which, moreover, should not be forgotten if one wants to understand its

The Eastern doctrines, and also the ancient Western doctrines, are unanimous in affirming that contemplation is superior to action, as the immutable is superior to change.¹⁰ Action, being only a transitory and momentary modification of the being, cannot contain in itself its principle or its sufficient reason; if it be not attached to a principle beyond its contingent domain, it is but a pure illusion. This principle, from which it derives all the reality of which it is capable, both its existence and even its possibility, can be found only in contemplation or, if one prefers, in knowledge, for at bottom these two terms are synonymous, or at least coincide, knowledge itself and the operation by which it is attained being in no wise separable.¹¹

Likewise, change, taken in its most general acceptation, is unintelligible and contradictory—that is to say, impossible—without a principle from which it proceeds and which, precisely because it is its principle, cannot be

meaning properly, is a book specifically intended for the use of *Kshatriyas*.

¹⁰ It is by virtue of this established relationship that it is said that the *Brahmin* is the type of stable beings, and that the *Kshatriya* is the type of mobile or changing beings; thus, all beings in this world, according to their nature, are primarily in relation with one or the other, for there is a perfect correspondence between the cosmic order and the human order.

¹¹ It should be noted, in fact, as a consequence of the essentially momentary nature of action, that, in the domain of action, the results are always separate from that which produces them, whereas knowledge, on the contrary, bears its fruit in itself.

subject to it and is therefore necessarily immutable. It is for this reason that, in Western antiquity, Aristotle affirmed the necessity of the “unmoved mover” of all things. This role of “unmoved mover” knowledge precisely fulfills in relation to action; it is evident that the latter belongs wholly to the world of change, of “becoming.” Knowledge alone permits one to pass beyond this world and the limitations inherent in it, and when it attains the immutable, as is the case with principial or metaphysical knowledge—which is knowledge in the highest sense—it itself possesses immutability, for all true knowledge is essentially identification with its object.

This is precisely what the modern Westerners do not know; in the matter of knowledge they envisage no longer anything but a rational and discursive knowing, therefore indirect and imperfect—what one might call a knowledge by reflection—and which, moreover, they value this inferior knowledge only insofar as it can serve immediately practical ends. Engaged in action to the point of denying all that surpasses it, they fail to perceive that this very action thus degenerates, through lack of principle, into an agitation at once vain and sterile.

Such indeed is the most visible character of the modern epoch: the need for incessant agitation, for continual change, for a speed ever increasing like that with which events themselves unfold. It is dispersion in multiplicity, and in a multiplicity no longer unified by the consciousness of any superior principle; it is, in ordinary life as in scientific conceptions, analysis pushed to the extreme,

indefinite fragmentation, a veritable disaggregation of human activity in all the orders wherein it may still be exercised; and hence the incapacity for synthesis, the impossibility of any concentration, so striking in the eyes of Orientals. These are the natural and inevitable consequences of a materialization ever more accentuated, for matter is essentially multiplicity and division, and this is why, let it be said in passing, all that proceeds from it can engender only struggles and conflicts of every sort, among peoples as among individuals. The more one sinks into matter, the more the elements of division and opposition are accentuated and amplified; inversely, the more one rises toward pure spirituality, the nearer one approaches unity, which can be fully realized only through the consciousness of universal principles. What is most strange is that movement and change are truly sought for themselves, and not in view of any end to which they may lead; and this fact results directly from the absorption of all human faculties in outward action, whose momentary character we have just indicated. It is dispersion envisaged under another aspect and at a more accentuated stage: it is, one might say, as though a tendency toward instantaneity, having for its limit a state of pure disequilibrium, which, if it could be attained, would coincide with the final dissolution of this world; and this is yet another of the clearest signs of the last period of the *Kali-Yuga*.

In this respect likewise, the same phenomenon appears in the scientific order: it is research for the sake of

research, far more than for the partial and fragmentary results to which it leads; it is the ever more rapid succession of theories and hypotheses without foundation, scarcely erected before they collapse to be replaced by others that will endure less still, a veritable chaos amid which it would be vain to seek any elements definitively acquired, save a monstrous accumulation of facts and details which can prove nothing and signify nothing. We speak here, of course, of what concerns the speculative point of view, insofar as it still subsists; as for practical applications, there are, on the contrary, incontestable results, and this is easily understood, since these applications relate immediately to the material domain, and that domain is precisely the only one wherein modern man can boast of a real superiority. One must therefore expect discoveries—or rather mechanical and industrial inventions—to continue developing and multiplying, ever more rapidly likewise, until the end of the present age; and who knows whether, with the dangers of destruction that they bear within themselves, they will not be among the principal agents of the ultimate catastrophe, should matters come to such a point that this cannot be avoided?

In any case, there is very generally felt the impression that, in the present state, no stability remains; but, while some perceive the danger and strive to react, most of our contemporaries take complacency in this disorder wherein they see as it were an exteriorized image of their own mentality. There is, indeed, an exact correspondence

between a world wherein all seems to be in pure “becoming,” wherein no place remains for the immutable and the permanent, and the state of mind of men who make all reality consist in this same “becoming,” which implies the negation of true knowledge as well as of the very object of that knowledge, namely transcendent and universal principles. One may go further still: it is the negation of all real knowledge in whatever order, even in the relative, since, as we have already indicated, the relative is unintelligible and impossible without the absolute, the contingent without the necessary, change without the immutable, multiplicity without unity; “relativism” contains a contradiction within itself, and when one would reduce everything to change, one ought logically to end by denying the very existence of change. At bottom, the celebrated arguments of Zeno of Elea had no other meaning.

It must indeed be said that theories of the kind in question are not exclusively proper to modern times, for nothing must be exaggerated; some examples may be found in Greek philosophy, and the case of Heraclitus, with his “universal flux,” is the best known in this regard; it was even what led the Eleatics to combat these conceptions, as well as those of the atomists, by a kind of reduction to the absurd. In India itself something comparable has occurred, though, of course, from another point of view than that of philosophy; certain Buddhist schools, in fact, presented the same character, for one of their principal theses was that of

the “dissolubility of all things.”¹² Only, such theories were then but exceptions, and such revolts against the traditional spirit, which could arise throughout the whole course of the *Kali-Yuga*, had in sum but a fairly limited scope; what is new is the generalization of similar conceptions, such as we observe in the contemporary West.

It must also be noted that the “philosophies of becoming,” under the influence of the very recent idea of “progress,” have assumed among the moderns a special form which theories of the same order had never possessed among the ancients: this form, moreover susceptible of many variations, is what may be designated in a general manner by the name of “evolutionism.” We shall not return to what we have said elsewhere on this subject; we shall merely recall that every conception which admits nothing other than “becoming” is thereby necessarily a “naturalistic” conception, and as such implies a formal negation of what lies beyond nature, that is to say, of the metaphysical

¹² Shortly after its origin, Buddhism in India became associated with one of the main manifestations of the *Kshatriya* revolt against *Brahmin* authority; and, as is easily understood from the preceding indications, there is, in general, a very direct link between the negation of any immutable principle and that of spiritual authority, between the reduction of all reality to “becoming” and the affirmation of the supremacy of temporal power, whose proper domain is the world of action; and one could observe that the appearance of “naturalistic” or anti-metaphysical doctrines always occurs when the element representing temporal power takes precedence, in a civilization, over that representing spiritual authority.

domain, which is the domain of immutable and eternal principles. We shall also note, with regard to these anti-metaphysical theories, that the Bergsonian idea of “pure duration” corresponds exactly to that dispersion in the instantaneous of which we spoke above; the supposed intuition that models itself upon the incessant flux of sensible things, far from being able to serve as the means of a true knowledge, represents in reality the dissolution of all possible knowledge.

This leads us to repeat once again—for this is an altogether essential point, and one on which it is indispensable that no ambiguity remain—that intellectual intuition, by which alone true metaphysical knowledge is obtained, has absolutely nothing in common with that other intuition of which certain contemporary philosophers speak: the latter is of the sensible order and is properly infra-rational, whereas the former, which is pure intelligence, is on the contrary supra-rational. But the moderns, who know nothing superior to reason in the order of intelligence, do not even conceive what intellectual intuition can be, whereas the doctrines of antiquity and of the Middle Ages, even when they possessed only a simply philosophical character and consequently could not effectively appeal to this intuition, nonetheless expressly recognized its existence and its supremacy over all the other faculties. This is why there was no “rationalism” before Descartes; that too is something specifically modern, and moreover closely bound up with “individualism,” since it is

nothing other than the negation of every faculty of a supra-individual order. So long as Westerners persist in ignoring or denying intellectual intuition, they can possess no tradition in the true sense of that word, nor can they come to an understanding with the authentic representatives of the Oriental civilizations, in which all is as it were suspended from that intuition, immutable and infallible in itself, and the unique point of departure of every development conformable to traditional norms.

-IV- SACRED AND PROFANE SCIENCE

WE HAVE JUST SAID THAT, in civilizations possessing a traditional character, intellectual intuition stands at the principle of all things; in other words, it is pure metaphysical doctrine that constitutes the essential, and all the rest is attached thereto as consequences or applications to the various orders of contingent reality. This is so in particular with social institutions; and, on the other hand, the same holds true also with regard to the sciences, that is to say, the forms of knowledge relating to the domain of the relative, which, in such civilizations, can be envisaged only as simple dependencies and, as it were, prolongations or reflections of absolute and principal knowledge. Thus the true hierarchy is everywhere and always observed: the relative is not held to be non-existent, which would be absurd; it is taken into account in the measure in which it deserves to be so, but it is set in its proper place, which can only be a secondary and subordinate place; and, within this relative itself, there are very diverse degrees, according as one deals with things more or less remote from the domain of principles.

There are therefore, with regard to the sciences, two conceptions radically different and even incompatible with one another, which we may call the traditional conception

and the modern conception. We have often had occasion to allude to those “traditional sciences” which existed in antiquity and in the Middle Ages, which still exist in the East, but whose very idea is wholly foreign to Westerners of the present day. It must be added that each civilization has had “traditional sciences” of a particular type belonging properly to itself; for here we are no longer in the order of universal principles, to which pure metaphysics alone relates, but in the order of adaptations, wherein, precisely because it is a contingent domain, account must be taken of the ensemble of conditions, mental and otherwise, that are those of such or such a determined people, and we may even say of such or such a period in the existence of that people, since we have seen above that there are epochs in which “re-adaptations” become necessary. These “re-adaptations” are nothing but changes of form, which in no way affect the very essence of the tradition; for metaphysical doctrine, only the expression can be modified, in a manner fairly comparable to the translation of one language into another; whatever the forms with which it is clothed in order to express itself so far as that is possible, there is absolutely but one metaphysics, just as there is but one truth. But when one passes to applications, the case is naturally different: with the sciences, as with social institutions, we are in the world of form and multiplicity; hence one may say that other forms truly constitute other sciences, even if they have, at least in part, the same object. Logicians are accustomed to regard a science as entirely defined by its

object, which is an inaccuracy born of excess simplification; the point of view under which that object is envisaged must also enter into the definition of the science. There is an indefinite multitude of possible sciences; it may happen that several sciences study the same things, but under aspects so different, and therefore by methods and with intentions likewise so different, that they are none the less sciences truly distinct. This case may occur in particular with the “traditional sciences” of diverse civilizations, which, though comparable with one another, are not always assimilable one to another, and often could only abusively be designated by the same names. The difference is yet far greater, as is evident, if instead of instituting a comparison between “traditional sciences,” which at least all share the same fundamental character, one wishes to compare these sciences, in a general way, with the sciences as the moderns conceive them; at first sight it may sometimes appear that the object is the same on either side, and yet the knowledge which the two kinds of sciences respectively give of that object is so different that, upon fuller examination, one hesitates still to affirm the identity, even under a certain relation only.

A few examples will not be useless for a clearer understanding of what is at issue; and, to begin with, we shall take an example of very wide bearing, that of “physics” as it is understood by the ancients and by the moderns; in this case, moreover, there is no need whatever to go outside the Western world in order to perceive the profound

difference that separates the two conceptions. The term “physics,” in its primary and etymological sense, signifies nothing other than “science of nature,” without any restriction; it is therefore the science that concerns the most general laws of “becoming,” for “nature” and “becoming” are at bottom synonymous, and it was indeed thus that the Greeks, and Aristotle in particular, understood it; if there exist more particular sciences relating to the same order, they are then but “specifications” of physics for such or such a more narrowly determined domain. There is therefore already something fairly significant in the deviation which the moderns have imposed upon this word “physics” by employing it exclusively to designate one particular science among other sciences which are all equally sciences of nature; this fact is connected with the fragmentation that we have already pointed out as one of the characters of modern science, with that “specialization” engendered by the analytic spirit and carried to the point of rendering truly inconceivable, for those who undergo its influence, a science bearing upon nature considered in its entirety. Some of the inconveniences of this “specialization,” and above all the narrowness of outlook which is its inevitable consequence, have often enough been remarked; yet it seems that even those who perceived them most clearly resigned themselves to regard them as a necessary evil, by reason of the accumulation of detailed knowledge which no man could grasp at a single glance; they did not understand, on the one hand, that these detailed knowledges are insignificant in

themselves and do not merit that a synthetic knowledge, which, even while remaining within the relative, is of a far higher order, should be sacrificed to them; and, on the other hand, that the impossibility in which one finds oneself of unifying their multiplicity arises solely from the fact that one has forbidden oneself to relate them to a superior principle, from the fact that one has obstinately proceeded from below and from the exterior, whereas it would have been necessary to do exactly the contrary in order to possess a science endowed with a real speculative value.

If one wishes to compare ancient physics, not with what the moderns designate by the same word, but with the ensemble of the sciences of nature as they are at present constituted—for that is what should in reality correspond to it—there is therefore first to be noted the division into multiple “specialties” which are as it were foreign to one another. Yet this is only the most external side of the question, and it must not be supposed that, by bringing together all these special sciences, one would obtain an equivalent of ancient physics. The truth is that the point of view is altogether different, and it is here that we see appear the essential difference between the two conceptions of which we spoke above: the traditional conception, we said, relates all the sciences to the principles as so many particular applications, and it is precisely this relation that the modern conception refuses to admit. For Aristotle, physics was only “second” with respect to metaphysics, that is to say, it was dependent upon it, and was in reality nothing but an

application, to the domain of nature, of principles superior to nature and reflected in its laws; and the same may be said of the medieval “cosmology.” The modern conception, on the contrary, claims to render the sciences independent by denying all that surpasses them, or at least by declaring it “unknowable” and refusing to take it into account, which comes in practice to the same denial; this negation existed in fact long before anyone thought of erecting it into a systematic theory under such names as “positivism” and “agnosticism,” for one may say that it is truly at the starting-point of all modern science. Only, it was scarcely until the nineteenth century that men were seen to make a boast of their ignorance, for to proclaim oneself “agnostic” is nothing else than that, and to pretend to forbid to all the knowledge of what one ignores oneself; and this marked yet another stage in the intellectual decline of the West.

In seeking radically to separate the sciences from every superior principle, under the pretext of assuring their independence, the modern conception deprives them of all profound significance and even of all true interest from the point of view of knowledge, and can lead only to a blind alley, since it confines them within a domain irremediably limited.¹³ The development that takes place within this

¹³ It may be noted that something similar has occurred in the social order, where modern thinkers have attempted to separate the temporal from the spiritual; it is not a matter of denying that these are two distinct things, since they do indeed relate to different domains, as in the case of metaphysics and the sciences; but, through an error inherent in the analytical mind, one forgets that distinction does not mean

domain is not, moreover, an inward deepening, as some imagine; it remains, on the contrary, wholly superficial, consisting only in that dispersion into detail which we have already indicated, in an analysis as sterile as it is laborious, and capable of being pursued indefinitely without advancing a single step upon the path of true knowledge. Nor, it must indeed be said, is it for its own sake that Westerners in general cultivate science thus understood: what they have chiefly in view is not knowledge, even of an inferior order, but practical applications; and to be convinced that this is so, one need only observe with what ease most of our contemporaries confound science with industry, and how numerous are those for whom the engineer represents the very type of the savant; but this relates to another question, which we shall have to treat more fully hereafter.

Science, in constituting itself after the modern fashion, has lost not only in depth but also, one might say, in stability; for its attachment to principles caused it to participate in their immutability in all the measure that its own object permitted, whereas, confined exclusively within the world of change, it finds therein nothing stable, no fixed point upon which it may rest; no longer proceeding from any absolute certitude, it is reduced to probabilities and approximations, or to purely hypothetical constructions which are but the work of individual fancy. Thus, even if it

separation; thereby, temporal power loses its legitimacy, and the same could be said, in the intellectual order, with regard to the sciences.

should happen accidentally that modern science, by a very circuitous path, arrives at certain results which seem to accord with some data of the ancient "traditional sciences," it would be a grave error to see in this a confirmation of which those data have no need; and it would be a waste of time to seek to reconcile totally different points of view, or to establish a concordance with hypothetical theories which may perhaps be wholly discredited within a few years.¹⁴ The matters in question can indeed, for present-day science, belong only to the domain of hypotheses, whereas, for the "traditional sciences," they were something altogether different and appeared as indubitable consequences of truths known intuitively, and therefore infallibly, in the metaphysical order.¹⁵ It is, moreover, a singular illusion, proper to modern "experimentalism," to believe that a theory can be proved by facts, whereas in reality the same facts can always be explained equally by several different theories; and some of the promoters of the experimental method themselves, such as Claude Bernard, have acknowledged that they could interpret them only with the

¹⁴ The same observation applies, from a religious point of view, to a certain "apologetics" which claims to agree with the results of modern science, a perfectly illusory and constantly evolving endeavor, which also presents the serious danger of appearing to align religion with changing and ephemeral conceptions, from which it must remain totally independent.

¹⁵ It would be easy to give examples here; we will only cite as one of the most striking, the difference in character of the conceptions concerning the ether in Hindu cosmology and in modern physics.

aid of “preconceived ideas,” without which these facts remained mere “brute facts,” devoid of all meaning and of all scientific value.

Since we have come to speak of “experimentalism,” we must take the occasion to answer a question that may here arise, namely this: why have the properly experimental sciences received, in modern civilization, a development such as they never possessed in other civilizations? It is because these sciences are those of the sensible world, those of matter, and also because they are those that give rise to the most immediate practical applications; their development, accompanied by what one might willingly call the “superstition of fact,” thus corresponds exactly to the specifically modern tendencies, whereas earlier epochs could not have found therein motives of sufficient interest to attach themselves to them to the point of neglecting knowledges of a higher order. It must be clearly understood that it is not in our thought to declare any knowledge whatsoever illegitimate in itself, even though it be inferior; what is illegitimate is only the abuse that arises when things of this kind absorb the whole of human activity, as we see at present. One might even conceive that, in a normal civilization, sciences constituted by an experimental method might, as well as others, be connected with principles and thereby endowed with a truly speculative value; in fact, if this case does not seem to have occurred, it is because attention was directed preferably elsewhere, and also because, even when it was a question of studying the

sensible world in so far as it might appear worthwhile to do so, traditional data allowed this study to be undertaken more advantageously by other methods and from another point of view.

We said above that one of the characters of the present epoch is the exploitation of all that had previously been neglected as having too secondary an importance for men to devote their activity to it, and which nevertheless had to be developed before the end of this cycle, since these things had their place among the possibilities called to manifestation therein; this is precisely the case, in particular, with the experimental sciences that have arisen in recent centuries. There are even certain modern sciences which represent, in the most literal sense, “residues” of ancient sciences now no longer understood: it is the lowest part of the latter which, isolating itself and detaching itself from the whole during a period of decadence, became grossly materialized, and then served as the point of departure for a wholly different development, in a direction conformable to modern tendencies, so as to lead to the constitution of sciences that truly have nothing in common with those which preceded them. Thus, for example, it is false to say, as is commonly done, that astrology and alchemy became respectively modern astronomy and chemistry, although there is in this opinion a certain element of truth from the purely historical point of view, an element of truth which is precisely that which we have just indicated: if the latter sciences do in a certain sense proceed from the former, it is

not by “evolution” or “progress,” as is claimed, but on the contrary by degeneration; and this still calls for some explanation.

It must first be observed that the attribution of distinct meanings to the terms “astrology” and “astronomy” is relatively recent; among the Greeks these two words were employed indifferently to designate the whole of what each now applies to separately. At first sight, then, it might seem that we have here again one of those divisions by “specialization” that have arisen between what was originally only parts of a single science; but what is particular in this case is that, while one of these parts, that which represented the most material side of the science in question, took on an independent development, the other part, on the contrary, disappeared altogether. This is so true that today no one any longer knows what ancient astrology could have been, and that even those who have attempted to reconstruct it have succeeded only in producing veritable counterfeits, whether by wishing to make of it the equivalent of a modern experimental science, with the intervention of statistics and the calculus of probabilities, which proceeds from a point of view that could in no way have been that of antiquity or of the Middle Ages, or by applying themselves exclusively to restoring a “divinatory art” which was scarcely more than a deviation of astrology already in decline, and in which one might see at most a very inferior application and one of little dignity, as may still be observed in certain Eastern civilizations.

The case of chemistry is perhaps even clearer and more characteristic; and as regards the ignorance of the moderns with respect to alchemy, it is at least as great as in the matter of astrology. True alchemy was essentially a science of cosmological order, and at the same time it was applicable also to the human order by virtue of the analogy of the “macrocosm” and the “microcosm”; moreover, it was expressly constituted with a view to allowing a transposition into the purely spiritual domain, which conferred upon its teachings a symbolic value and a higher signification, and which made of it one of the most complete types of the “traditional sciences.” What gave birth to modern chemistry is not this alchemy, with which it in sum has no relation; it is rather a deformation, a deviation in the most rigorous sense of the word, a deviation to which there gave rise, perhaps already in the Middle Ages, the incomprehension of certain individuals who, incapable of penetrating the true meaning of the symbols, took everything literally and, believing that it was a question only of material operations, launched themselves into an experimentation more or less disordered. These are those whom the alchemists qualified ironically as “blowers” and “burners of charcoal,” and who were in truth the precursors of present-day chemists; and thus modern science is built out of the debris of ancient sciences, with the materials rejected by the latter and abandoned to the ignorant and the “profane.” Let us add that the so-called renovators of alchemy, of whom a few are to be found among our contemporaries, do nothing on their side but

prolong this same deviation, and that their researches are as far removed from traditional alchemy as those of the astrologers to whom we alluded just now are from ancient astrology; and this is why we have the right to affirm that the “traditional sciences” of the West are truly lost to the moderns.

We shall confine ourselves to these few examples; it would, however, be easy to give others, taken from somewhat different orders, and everywhere showing the same degeneration. One might thus show that psychology as it is understood today, that is to say the study of mental phenomena as such, is a natural product of Anglo-Saxon empiricism and of the spirit of the eighteenth century, and that the point of view to which it corresponds was so negligible for the ancients that, if they happened at times to envisage it incidentally, they would in any case never have thought of making of it a special science; all that there may be of value in it was, for them, transformed and assimilated into higher points of view. In an altogether different domain, one might also show that modern mathematics represents scarcely more than the shell of Pythagorean mathematics, its purely “exoteric” side; the ancient idea of numbers has even become absolutely unintelligible to the moderns, because there too the higher part of the science, that which gave it, together with its traditional character, a properly intellectual value, has totally disappeared; and this case is fairly comparable to that of astrology. But we cannot review all the sciences one after another, which would be

rather tedious; we think we have said enough to make understood the nature of the change to which the modern sciences owe their origin, and which is the very opposite of a “progress,” being a veritable regression of the intelligence; and we shall now return to considerations of a general order on the respective role of the “traditional sciences” and the modern sciences, on the profound difference that exists between the true destination of the former and of the latter. Any science whatsoever, according to the traditional conception, has less its interest in itself than in that it is as it were a prolongation or a secondary branch of the doctrine, whose essential part is constituted, as we have said, by pure metaphysics.¹⁶ For if every science is assuredly legitimate, provided that it occupies only the place that truly befits it by reason of its proper nature, it is nevertheless easy to understand that, for whoever possesses a knowledge of a higher order, inferior knowledges necessarily lose much of their interest, and indeed retain it only, so to speak, as a function of principal knowledge, that is to say in so far as, on the one hand, they reflect this latter in such or such a contingent domain, and in so far as, on the other hand, they are capable of leading toward this same principal knowledge, which in the case we are considering can never be lost sight of nor sacrificed to considerations more or less

¹⁶ This is expressed, for example, by a designation such as *upaveda*, applied in India to certain “traditional sciences” and indicating their subordination to the Veda, that is to say, to sacred knowledge par excellence.

accidental. These are the two complementary roles that belong properly to the “traditional sciences”: on the one hand, as applications of the doctrine, they permit the linking together of all orders of reality, integrating them into the unity of the total synthesis; on the other hand, they are, at least for certain persons and in conformity with their aptitudes, a preparation for a higher knowledge, a kind of approach toward the latter, and, in their hierarchical distribution according to the degrees of existence to which they correspond, they then constitute as it were so many steps by means of which it is possible to rise to pure intellectuality.¹⁷ It is only too evident that the modern sciences cannot, in any degree, fulfill either of these two roles; this is why they are and can be only “profane science,” whereas the “traditional sciences,” by their connection with metaphysical principles, are effectively incorporated into “sacred science.”

The coexistence of the two roles that we have just indicated implies neither contradiction nor vicious circle, contrary to what might be supposed by those who view things only superficially; and this again is a point upon which we must insist somewhat. One might say that there are here two points of view, one descending and the other

¹⁷ In our study on Dante's Esotericism, we indicated the symbolism of the ladder whose rungs, according to various traditions, correspond to certain sciences as well as to states of being, which necessarily implies that these sciences, instead of being considered in a completely "profane" way as with modern thinkers, gave rise to a transposition conferring upon them a truly "initiatory" scope.

ascending, of which the first corresponds to a development of knowledge proceeding from principles toward applications ever more remote from them, and the second to a gradual acquisition of that same knowledge by proceeding from the inferior to the superior, or again, if one prefers, from the exterior to the interior. The question, therefore, is not whether the sciences ought to be constituted from below upward or from above downward, whether, in order that they be possible, one must take as starting-point the knowledge of principles or, on the contrary, that of the sensible world; this question, which may arise from the point of view of “profane” philosophy, and which in fact seems to have been posed in that domain, more or less explicitly, by Greek antiquity, this question, we say, does not exist for “sacred science,” which can proceed only from universal principles; and what here removes any ground for it is the primordial role of intellectual intuition, which is the most immediate of all knowledges as well as the highest, and which is absolutely independent of the exercise of any faculty of a sensible or even of a rational order. Sciences can be validly constituted, as “sacred sciences,” only by those who, before all else, fully possess principal knowledge, and who thereby alone are qualified to realize, in conformity with the most rigorous traditional orthodoxy, all the adaptations required by circumstances of time and place. Once the sciences are thus constituted, however, their teaching may follow an inverse order: they are in some sort like “illustrations” of the pure doctrine, capable of rendering

it more readily accessible to certain minds; and precisely because they concern the world of multiplicity, the almost indefinite diversity of their points of view may suit the no less great diversity of the individual aptitudes of those minds whose horizon is still bounded by that same world of multiplicity; the possible ways of attaining knowledge may be extremely different at the lowest degree, and thereafter they become ever more unified as one reaches higher stages. Not that any of these preparatory degrees is of absolute necessity, since they are but contingent means and without commensurability with the end to be attained; it may even happen that certain among those in whom the contemplative tendency predominates rise to true intellectual intuition at a single bound and without the aid of such means,¹⁸ but this is rather an exceptional case, and most commonly there is what might be called a necessity of congruity to proceed in the ascending sense.

To make this understood one may also employ the traditional image of the “cosmic wheel”: the circumference exists in reality only by the center; yet beings who are on the circumference must necessarily set out from it, or more precisely from the point of it where they are situated, and follow the radius in order to reach the center. Moreover, by virtue of the correspondence that exists between all orders of

¹⁸ Therefore, according to Hindu doctrine, *Brahmins* must keep their minds constantly directed towards supreme knowledge, while *Kshatriyas* should instead apply themselves to the successive study of the various stages by which it is gradually attained.

reality, the truths of an inferior order may be regarded as a symbol of those of superior orders and may consequently serve as a “support” for arriving analogically at the knowledge of the latter;¹⁹ this is what confers upon every science a superior or “anagogical” sense, more profound than that which it possesses in itself, and what can give it the character of a veritable “sacred science.”

Every science, we say, can assume this character, whatever its object may be, on the sole condition that it be constituted and regarded according to the traditional spirit; it is necessary only, in this respect, to take account of the degrees of importance of the sciences, according to the hierarchical rank of the diverse realities to which they refer; yet, at one degree or another, their character and their function are essentially the same in the traditional conception. What is true here of every science is equally true of every art, in so far as the latter may possess a properly symbolic value rendering it apt to furnish “supports” for meditation, and likewise in so far as its rules are, like the laws whose knowledge is the object of the sciences, reflections and applications of fundamental principles; thus there exist, in every normal civilization, “traditional arts,” no less

¹⁹ This is the role played, for example, by astronomical symbolism so frequently employed in various traditional doctrines; and what we say here may give a glimpse into the true nature of a science such as ancient astrology.

unknown to modern Westerners than the “traditional sciences.”²⁰

The truth is that there does not in reality exist a “profane domain” which would in some fashion stand opposed to the “sacred domain”; there exists only a “profane point of view,” which is properly nothing other than the point of view of ignorance.²¹ For this reason “profane science,” that of the moderns, may rightly, as we have said elsewhere, be regarded as an “ignorant knowledge”: a knowledge of inferior order, wholly confined to the level of the lowest reality, and ignorant of all that surpasses it, ignorant alike of every end superior to itself and of every principle that might assure it a legitimate place, however humble, among the diverse orders of integral knowledge; irredeemably enclosed within the relative and limited domain wherein it has willed to proclaim itself independent, and thus having itself severed every communication with transcendent truth and with supreme knowledge, it is no more than a vain and illusory science, which in truth comes from nothing and leads to nothing.

²⁰ The art of medieval builders can be mentioned as a particularly remarkable example of these “traditional arts”, the practice of which also implied a real knowledge of the corresponding sciences.

²¹ To be convinced of this, one only needs to observe facts like this: one of the most “sacred” sciences, cosmogony, which has its place as such in all inspired books, including the Hebrew Bible, has become, for moderns, the object of the most purely “profane” hypotheses; the domain of science is indeed the same in both cases, but the point of view is totally different.

This exposition will make it possible to understand all that the modern world lacks in respect of science, and how that very science of which it is so proud represents no more than a simple deviation and, as it were, a residue of true science, which for us is wholly identical with what we have called “sacred science” or “traditional science.” Modern science, proceeding from an arbitrary limitation of knowledge to a certain particular order—and that the lowest of all, the order of material or sensible reality—has, by reason of this limitation and of the consequences that immediately follow from it, lost all intellectual value, at least if one accords to intellectuality the fullness of its true sense, if one refuses to share in the “rationalist” error, that is to say, to assimilate pure intelligence to reason, or, which comes to the same thing, to deny intellectual intuition.

What lies at the root of this error, as of a great part of the other modern errors, what stands at the very origin of the whole deviation of science such as we have just explained it, is what may be called “individualism,” which is one with the antitraditional spirit itself, and whose multiple manifestations, in every domain, constitute one of the most important factors in the disorder of our age; it is this “individualism” that we must now examine more closely.

-V- INDIVIDUALISM

What we understand by “individualism” is the negation of every principle superior to individuality and, consequently, the reduction of civilization, in every domain, to purely human elements alone; it is thus, at bottom, the same thing as what, at the time of the Renaissance, was designated by the name of “humanism,” as we have said above, and it is likewise what properly characterizes what we have just called the “profane point of view.” All this, in sum, is but one and the same thing under diverse designations; and we have also said that this “profane” spirit is identical with the antitraditional spirit, in which are summed up all the tendencies specifically modern. Doubtless this spirit is not wholly new; it has already had, at other epochs, manifestations more or less accentuated, yet always limited and aberrant, and which had never extended to the whole of a civilization as they have done in the West during these last centuries. What had never yet been seen is a civilization erected in its entirety upon something purely negative, upon what one might call an absence of principle; and it is precisely this that gives the modern world its abnormal character, that makes of it a kind of monstrosity, explicable only if one considers it as corresponding to the end of a

cyclic period, in accordance with what we explained at the outset. It is indeed individualism, such as we have just defined it, that is the determining cause of the present decadence of the West, precisely because it is, as it were, the motor of the exclusive development of the lowest possibilities of humanity, those whose expansion requires the intervention of no supra-human element, and which indeed cannot be fully deployed save in the absence of such an element, because they stand at the extreme opposite of all spirituality and of all true intellectuality.

Individualism implies first of all the negation of intellectual intuition, insofar as this is essentially a supra-individual faculty, and of the order of knowledge that is the proper domain of this intuition, that is to say, of metaphysics understood in its true sense. This is why all that modern philosophers designate by the same name of metaphysics, when they admit anything they so call, has absolutely nothing in common with true metaphysics: they are but rational constructions or imaginative hypotheses, therefore wholly individual conceptions, and the greater part of them, moreover, relates simply to the “physical” domain, that is to say, to nature. Even if there be found therein some question that might effectively be attached to the metaphysical order, the manner in which it is envisaged and treated reduces it still to being no more than a “pseudo-metaphysics,” and renders, besides, any real and valid solution impossible; it even seems that, for philosophers, it is a matter of posing “problems,” though

artificial and illusory, far more than of resolving them, which is one aspect of that disordered need of research for its own sake, that is to say, of the most vain agitation in the mental order as in the corporeal. It is likewise a matter, for these same philosophers, of attaching their name to a “system,” that is to say, to a strictly bounded and delimited ensemble of theories that shall be wholly their own and nothing other than their personal work; hence the desire to be original at any cost, even if truth must be sacrificed to that originality: it is better, for the renown of a philosopher, to invent a new error than to restate a truth already expressed by others. This form of individualism, to which we owe so many “systems” contradictory one with another when they are not so in themselves, is found no less among modern savants and artists; but it is perhaps among philosophers that one may most clearly see the intellectual anarchy that is its inevitable consequence.

In a traditional civilization it is almost inconceivable that a man should claim the ownership of an idea, and in any case, if he does so, he thereby deprives himself of all credit and authority, for he thus reduces it to being no more than a sort of fantasy devoid of any real reach: if an idea is true, it belongs equally to all who are capable of understanding it; if it is false, there is no glory in having invented it. A true idea cannot be “new,” for truth is not a product of the human mind; it exists independently of us, and we have only to know it; apart from such knowledge there can be nothing but error. But in truth do the moderns

care for truth, and do they even still know what it is? Here again words have lost their meaning, since some, such as the contemporary “pragmatists,” go so far as abusively to give this name of “truth” to what is simply practical utility, that is to say, to something wholly foreign to the intellectual order; this, as the logical outcome of the modern deviation, is the very negation of truth, as of the intelligence whose proper object it is. But let us not anticipate further, and on this point let us remark only that the kind of individualism just spoken of is the source of the illusions concerning the role of “great men,” or so-called such; “genius,” understood in the “profane” sense, is in reality a very small thing, and can in no way make good the lack of true knowledge.

Since we have spoken of philosophy, we shall indicate also, without entering into all the details, some of the consequences of individualism in this domain: the first of all was, through the negation of intellectual intuition, to set reason above everything, to make of this purely human and relative faculty the superior part of intelligence, or even to reduce intelligence to it entirely; this is what constitutes “rationalism,” whose true founder was Descartes. This limitation of intelligence, moreover, was only a first stage; reason itself was soon to be more and more debased to a chiefly practical role, in proportion as applications took precedence over those sciences that could still retain a certain speculative character; and already Descartes himself was, at bottom, far more preoccupied with these practical applications than with pure science. But this is not all:

individualism inevitably entails “naturalism,” since all that lies beyond nature is thereby beyond the reach of the individual as such; “naturalism,” or the negation of metaphysics, is indeed one and the same thing, and once intellectual intuition is ignored there is no longer any metaphysics possible; yet while some persist nevertheless in building some sort of “pseudo-metaphysics,” others more frankly acknowledge this impossibility; hence “relativism” in all its forms, whether the “criticism” of Kant or the “positivism” of Auguste Comte; and reason itself being wholly relative and able to apply validly only to a likewise relative domain, it is indeed true that “relativism” is the sole logical outcome of “rationalism.” The latter, moreover, was bound thereby to destroy itself: “nature” and “becoming,” as we have noted above, are in reality synonymous; a “naturalism” consistent with itself can therefore be nothing but one of those “philosophies of becoming” of which we have already spoken, and whose specifically modern type is “evolutionism”; but it is precisely this that was finally to turn against “rationalism,” reproaching reason with its inability adequately to grasp what is nothing but change and pure multiplicity, or to enclose within its concepts the indefinite complexity of sensible things. Such indeed is the position adopted by that form of “evolutionism” which is Bergsonian “intuitionism,” which, of course, is no less individualist and anti-metaphysical than “rationalism,” and which, while rightly criticizing the latter, falls still lower by appealing to a faculty properly infra-rational, to a sensible

intuition ill defined enough, and more or less mingled with imagination, instinct, and feeling. What is highly significant is that here there is no longer even any question of “truth,” but only of “reality,” reduced exclusively to the sensible order and conceived as something essentially mobile and unstable; with such theories intelligence is truly reduced to its lowest part, and reason itself is admitted only insofar as it applies to shaping matter for industrial uses. After that there remained but one step to take: the total negation of intelligence and of knowledge, the substitution of “utility” for “truth”; this was “pragmatism,” to which we have already alluded above; and here we are no longer even in the purely human, as with “rationalism,” but truly in the infra-human, with the appeal to the “subconscious” that marks the complete inversion of every normal hierarchy.

Such, in its broad outlines, is the course that philosophy “profane,” abandoned to itself and claiming to limit all knowledge to its own horizon, was bound to follow and has in fact followed; so long as a superior knowledge existed, nothing of the kind could occur, for philosophy was at least obliged to respect what it ignored and could not deny it; but when that superior knowledge disappeared, its negation, which corresponded to the state of fact, was soon erected into theory, and from this proceeds the whole of modern philosophy.

But enough has been said concerning philosophy, to which it would be unfitting to attribute an excessive importance, whatever place it may seem to occupy in the

modern world; from the point of view at which we stand, it is chiefly of interest insofar as it expresses, in a form as clearly defined as possible, the tendencies of a given moment, far more than it truly creates them; and, if it may be said to guide them to a certain extent, it does so only secondarily and after the event. Thus it is certain that all modern philosophy has its origin in Descartes; yet the influence which he exercised first upon his own age and then upon those that followed, and which was not confined to philosophers alone, would not have been possible had his conceptions not corresponded to pre-existing tendencies, which were in sum those of the generality of his contemporaries; the modern spirit recognized itself in Cartesianism and, through it, attained a clearer consciousness of itself than it had possessed until then. Moreover, in whatever domain it appears, a movement as manifest as Cartesianism was in the philosophical order is always a resultant rather than a true point of departure; it is not something spontaneous, but the product of a whole latent and diffused labour; if a man such as Descartes is particularly representative of the modern deviation, if it may be said that he in some measure embodies it from a certain point of view, he is nonetheless neither its sole nor its first responsible cause, and one would have to go much farther back to discover the roots of that deviation. In like manner, the Renaissance and the Reformation, which are most often regarded as the first great manifestations of the modern spirit, completed the rupture with tradition far more than

they provoked it; for us, the beginning of that rupture dates from the fourteenth century, and it is there, and not one or two centuries later, that the modern times must in reality be said to commence.

It is upon this rupture with tradition that we must still insist, since from it the modern world was born, whose proper characters might all be summed up in a single one, opposition to the traditional spirit; and the negation of tradition is once again individualism. This, moreover, is in perfect accord with what precedes, for, as we have explained, intellectual intuition and pure metaphysical doctrine stand at the principle of every traditional civilization; once the principle is denied, all its consequences are likewise denied, at least implicitly, and thus the whole ensemble of what truly deserves the name of tradition is thereby destroyed. We have already seen what has occurred in this respect with regard to the sciences; we shall not return to it, but shall consider another side of the question, where the manifestations of the anti-traditional spirit are perhaps even more immediately visible, because here it is a matter of changes that have directly affected the Western mass itself. Indeed, the “traditional sciences” of the Middle Ages were reserved to an elite more or less restricted, and some of them were even the exclusive domain of very closed schools, constituting an “esoterism” in the strictest sense of the word; but, on the other hand, there was also in the tradition something that was common to all without distinction, and it is of this outward part that we now wish to speak. The

Western tradition was then, outwardly, a tradition of specifically religious form, represented by Catholicism; it is therefore in the religious domain that we shall have to consider the revolt against the traditional spirit, a revolt which, when it assumed a definite form, was called Protestantism; and it is easy to perceive that this is indeed a manifestation of individualism, to such an extent that one might say that it is nothing other than individualism itself considered in its application to religion. What constitutes Protestantism, as what constitutes the modern world, is nothing but a negation, that negation of principles which is the very essence of individualism; and one may see here again one of the most striking examples of the state of anarchy and dissolution which is its consequence.

Individualism necessarily implies the refusal to admit any authority superior to the individual, as well as any faculty of knowledge superior to individual reason; the two things are inseparable. Consequently, the modern spirit was bound to reject every spiritual authority in the true sense of the word, taking its source in the supra-human order, and every traditional organization founded essentially upon such an authority, whatever form it might assume, a form which naturally differs according to civilizations. This is indeed what occurred: in place of the authority of the organization qualified to interpret legitimately the religious tradition of the West, Protestantism claimed to substitute what it called “private judgment,” that is to say, interpretation abandoned to the arbitrariness of each, even of the ignorant and the

incompetent, and founded solely upon the exercise of human reason. It was therefore, in the religious domain, the analogue of what was to be “rationalism” in philosophy; it was the door opened to all discussions, to all divergences, to all deviations; and the result was what it had to be: dispersion into a multitude ever increasing of sects, each of which represents only the particular opinion of a few individuals. Since, under such conditions, agreement upon doctrine became impossible, doctrine quickly passed into the background, and it was the secondary side of religion, we mean morality, which took first place: hence that degeneration into “moralism” which is so perceptible in present-day Protestantism. There occurred here a phenomenon parallel to that which we have noted with regard to philosophy; doctrinal dissolution, the disappearance of the intellectual elements of religion, entailed this inevitable consequence: starting from “rationalism,” one had to fall into “sentimentalism,” and it is in the Anglo-Saxon countries that one might find the most striking examples of this. What is then in question is no longer religion, even diminished and deformed, but simply “religiosity,” that is to say, vague sentimental aspirations justified by no real knowledge; and to this final stage correspond theories such as that of the “religious experience” of William James, which goes so far as to see in the “subconscious” the means whereby man enters into communication with the divine. Here the latest products of religious decadence merge with those of philosophical

decadence: “religious experience” incorporates itself into “pragmatism,” in the name of which there is advocated the idea of a limited God as more “advantageous” than that of the infinite God, because one may feel toward Him sentiments comparable to those felt toward a superior man; and at the same time, through the appeal to the “subconscious,” one arrives at a junction with spiritism and with all the “pseudo-religions” characteristic of our epoch, which we have studied elsewhere. On the other hand, Protestant morality, eliminating more and more every doctrinal basis, ends by degenerating into what is called “secular morality,” which counts among its partisans the representatives of all varieties of “liberal Protestantism” as well as the declared adversaries of every religious idea; fundamentally, in both, the same tendencies predominate, and the sole difference is that all do not proceed equally far in the logical development of what those tendencies imply.

Indeed, religion being properly a form of tradition, the anti-traditional spirit can only be anti-religious; it begins by denaturing religion, and, when it can, it ends by suppressing it altogether. Protestantism is illogical in that, while striving to “humanize” religion, it nevertheless leaves subsisting, at least in theory, a supra-human element, namely revelation; it does not dare push the negation to its conclusion, but, by delivering that revelation to all the discussions which are the consequence of purely human interpretations, it reduces it in fact to being soon nothing at all; and when one sees persons who, while continuing to call

themselves “Christians,” no longer even admit the divinity of Christ, one may well think that such as these, perhaps without knowing it, are far nearer to complete negation than to true Christianity. Such contradictions, moreover, should not surprise us unduly, for they are, in every domain, one of the symptoms of our epoch of disorder and confusion, just as the incessant division of Protestantism is but one of the many manifestations of that dispersion into multiplicity which, as we have said, is found everywhere in modern life and science. It is natural also that Protestantism, with the spirit of negation that animates it, should have given birth to that dissolving “criticism” which, in the hands of the so-called “historians of religions,” has become a weapon of combat against every religion, and that thus, while pretending to recognize no authority other than that of the Sacred Books, it has contributed in large part to the destruction of that same authority, that is to say, of the minimum of tradition which it still preserved; the revolt against the traditional spirit, once begun, could not stop halfway.

One might here raise an objection: would it not have been possible that, while separating itself from the Catholic organization, Protestantism, by the very fact that it nevertheless admitted the Sacred Books, should have preserved the traditional doctrine contained therein? It is the introduction of “private judgment” that absolutely opposes such a hypothesis, since it permits every individual fantasy; the conservation of doctrine moreover presupposes

an organized traditional teaching, whereby orthodox interpretation is maintained, and in fact that teaching, in the Western world, was identified with Catholicism. Doubtless, in other civilizations there may be organizations of forms very different from that one to fulfil the corresponding function; but it is of Western civilization, with its particular conditions, that we are here speaking. One cannot therefore urge that, for example, in India there exists no institution comparable to the Papacy; the case is wholly different, first because one is not dealing there with a tradition of religious form in the Western sense of the word, so that the means whereby it is conserved and transmitted cannot be the same, and next because, the Hindu spirit being altogether other than the European spirit, the tradition may in the former case possess in itself a power which it could not possess in the latter without the support of an organization much more strictly defined in its outward constitution. We have already said that the Western tradition, since Christianity, had necessarily to be clothed in a religious form; it would be too long to explain here all the reasons for this, which cannot be fully understood without recourse to considerations sufficiently complex; but it is a fact from which one cannot refuse to draw account,²² and from that moment one must also admit all the consequences that

²² This state must, moreover, be maintained, according to the Gospel, until the "consummation of the age," that is to say, until the end of the current cycle.

follow from it with regard to the organization appropriate to such a traditional form.

On the other hand, it is indeed certain, as we have also indicated above, that it is in Catholicism alone that there has been preserved, despite all, what still subsists of the traditional spirit in the West; but does this mean that, there at least, one may speak of an integral conservation of the tradition, sheltered from every encroachment of the modern spirit? Unfortunately, it does not appear to be so; or, to speak more exactly, if the deposit of the tradition has remained intact, which is already much, it is highly doubtful whether its profound sense is still effectively understood, even by a small elite whose existence would doubtless manifest itself by an action, or rather by an influence, which in fact we perceive nowhere. It is therefore more probable that what we have here is what we should willingly call a conservation in a latent state, always permitting those who shall be capable of it to recover the sense of the tradition, even though that sense may at present be conscious for no one; and there are moreover, scattered here and there throughout the Western world, outside the religious domain, many signs or symbols deriving from ancient traditional doctrines, which are preserved without being understood. In such cases, a contact with the fully living traditional spirit is necessary in order to awaken what is thus plunged into a kind of sleep and to restore the lost understanding; and let us repeat once again that it is above all in this respect that the West will need the assistance of the

East if it would return to the consciousness of its own tradition.

What we have just said relates properly to the possibilities which Catholicism, by its principle, bears within itself in a constant and inalterable manner; here, consequently, the influence of the modern spirit is necessarily confined to preventing, during a period more or less prolonged, that certain things be effectively understood. On the other hand, if by the present state of Catholicism one wished to understand the manner in which it is envisaged by the great majority of its adherents themselves, one would be obliged to note a more positive action of the modern spirit, if that expression may be used for something which in reality is essentially negative. What we have in view in this regard is not merely movements sufficiently well defined, such as that to which the name “modernism” has been given, and which was nothing other than an attempt, fortunately thwarted, at the infiltration of the Protestant spirit within the Catholic Church itself; it is above all a state of mind far more general, more diffused, and more difficult to grasp, therefore more dangerous still, and all the more dangerous because it is often entirely unconscious in those who are affected by it: one may believe oneself sincerely religious and not be so in the least at bottom, one may even call oneself “traditionalist” without possessing the least notion of the true traditional spirit, and this again is one of the symptoms of the mental disorder of our epoch. The state of mind to which we allude is, first of all, that which

consists, so to speak, in “minimizing” religion, in making of it something set apart, to which one assigns a place as narrowly delimited as possible, something having no real influence upon the rest of existence, isolated from it by a sort of watertight partition; are there today many Catholics whose habitual ways of thinking and acting differ sensibly from those of their most irreligious contemporaries? It is also an almost complete ignorance from the doctrinal point of view, even an indifference toward all that pertains to it; religion, for many, is simply a matter of “practice,” of habit, not to say of routine, and one carefully refrains from seeking to understand anything whatever in it; one even comes to think that it is useless to understand, or perhaps that there is nothing to understand; moreover, if one truly understood religion, could one assign it so mediocre a place among one’s concerns? Doctrine is thus, in fact, forgotten or reduced to almost nothing, which comes singularly close to the Protestant conception, because it is an effect of the same modern tendencies opposed to all intellectuality; and what is most deplorable is that the teaching generally given, instead of reacting against this state of mind, on the contrary favours it by adapting itself only too well to it: one speaks always of morality, one speaks almost never of doctrine, under the pretext that one would not be understood; religion now is no more than “moralism,” or at least it seems that no one any longer wishes to see what it really is, which is something altogether different. If one still sometimes comes to speak of doctrine, it is too often only to

abase it by discussing with adversaries upon their own “profane” ground, which inevitably leads to making to them the most unjustified concessions; thus, in particular, one believes oneself obliged to take into account, in a greater or lesser measure, the pretended results of modern “criticism,” whereas nothing would be easier, by placing oneself at another point of view, than to show their complete vanity; under such conditions, what can effectively remain of the true traditional spirit?

This digression, into which we have been led by the examination of the manifestations of individualism in the religious domain, does not seem to us useless, for it shows that the evil in this respect is yet more grave and more extended than one might at first sight believe; and, on the other hand, it does not carry us far from the question we were considering, to which our last remark is even directly connected, for it is again individualism that everywhere introduces the spirit of discussion. It is very difficult to make our contemporaries understand that there are things which, by their very nature, cannot be discussed; the modern man, instead of seeking to raise himself to the truth, pretends to make it descend to his own level; and this is doubtless why there are so many who, when one speaks to them of “traditional sciences” or even of pure metaphysics, imagine that there is question only of “profane science” and of “philosophy.” In the domain of individual opinions one can always discuss, because one does not pass beyond the rational order, and because, appealing to no superior

principle, one easily finds arguments more or less valid to sustain the “for” and the “against”; one may even, in many cases, prolong discussion indefinitely without arriving at any solution, and thus almost all modern philosophy is made up only of equivocations and badly posed questions. Far from clarifying questions, as is ordinarily supposed, discussion most often does little more than displace them, if indeed it does not further obscure them; and the most usual result is that each, in striving to convince his adversary, clings more than ever to his own opinion and shuts himself within it in a manner still more exclusive than before. In all this, at bottom, it is not a matter of arriving at the knowledge of the truth, but of being right at all costs, or at least of persuading oneself that one is, if one cannot persuade others, which one will regret all the more in that there is always mingled with it that need for “proselytism” which is again one of the most characteristic elements of the Western spirit. Sometimes individualism, in the most ordinary and lowest sense of the word, manifests itself in a manner yet more apparent: thus does one not see at every moment people who wish to judge the work of a man according to what they know of his private life, as though there could be any relation between the two? From the same tendency, joined to the mania for detail, there also derive, let us note it in passing, the interest attached to the least particularities of the existence of “great men,” and the illusion one entertains of explaining all that they have done by a sort of “psycho-physiological” analysis;

all this is indeed significant for whoever wishes to understand what the contemporary mentality truly is.

But let us return for a moment to the introduction of habits of discussion into domains where they have no place, and let us say plainly this: the “apologetic” attitude is, in itself, an extremely weak attitude, because it is purely “defensive,” in the juridical sense of the word; it is not without reason that it is designated by a term derived from “apology,” which properly signifies the pleading of an advocate, and which, in a language such as English, has even come commonly to bear the meaning of an “excuse”; the preponderant importance accorded to “apologetics” is therefore the incontestable mark of a retreat of the religious spirit. This weakness is accentuated still further when “apologetics” degenerates, as we were saying just now, into discussions wholly “profane” in their method and point of view, wherein religion is placed on the same level as the most contingent and hypothetical philosophical and scientific, or pseudo-scientific, theories, and wherein, in order to appear “conciliatory,” one goes so far as to admit in a certain measure conceptions that were invented solely to ruin all religion; those who act thus furnish by that very fact the proof that they are perfectly unconscious of the true character of the doctrine of which they believe themselves the more or less authorized representatives. Those who are qualified to speak in the name of a traditional doctrine have no need to discuss with the “profane” nor to engage in “polemics”; they have only to expound the doctrine such as

it is, for those who are capable of understanding it, and at the same time to denounce error wherever it is found, to make it appear as such by projecting upon it the light of true knowledge; their role is not to enter into struggle and thereby compromise the doctrine, but to pronounce the judgment they have the right to pronounce if they effectively possess the principles which must inspire them infallibly. The domain of struggle is that of action, that is to say the individual and temporal domain; the “unmoved mover” produces and directs movement without being carried away by it; knowledge illumines action without sharing in its vicissitudes; the spiritual guides the temporal without mingling with it; and thus each thing remains within its order, at the rank which belongs to it in the universal hierarchy. But in the modern world, where can one still find the notion of a true hierarchy? Nothing and no one is any longer in the place where it should normally be; men no longer recognize any effective authority in the spiritual order, nor any legitimate power in the temporal order; the “profane” permit themselves to discuss sacred things, to contest their character and even their very existence; it is the inferior that judges the superior, ignorance that imposes limits upon wisdom, error that takes precedence over truth, the human that substitutes itself for the divine, the earth that prevails over the heaven, the individual that makes himself the measure of all things and pretends to dictate to the universe laws drawn entirely from his own relative and fallible reason. “Woe unto you, blind guides,” it is said in the

Gospel; today indeed one sees everywhere only blind men leading other blind men, and who, if they are not halted in time, will inevitably lead them into the abyss where they will perish with them.

-VI- THE SOCIAL CHAOS

WE DO NOT INTEND, in the present study, to dwell particularly upon the social point of view, which concerns us only very indirectly, inasmuch as it represents but a remote application of fundamental principles, and since it is not in that domain that any rectification of the modern world could, in any case, take its beginning. Such a rectification, if it were undertaken in reverse order, that is to say by setting out from consequences instead of from principles, would necessarily lack any serious foundation and would be altogether illusory; nothing stable could ever result from it, and all would have to be begun anew without ceasing, because agreement would not first have been reached upon essential truths. For this reason it is not possible for us to accord to political contingencies, even if the word be taken in its widest sense, any value other than that of simple outward signs of the mentality of an epoch; yet, even under this aspect, we cannot entirely pass over in silence the manifestations of modern disorder in the social domain properly so called.

As we indicated a moment ago, in the present state of the Western world no one any longer occupies the place that normally befits him by reason of his own nature; this is

what is expressed in saying that the castes no longer exist, for caste, understood in its true traditional sense, is nothing other than individual nature itself, together with the whole ensemble of the special aptitudes it comprises, and which predispose each man to the accomplishment of such or such a determinate function. From the moment that accession to functions of whatever kind is no longer subject to any legitimate rule, it follows inevitably that each will be led to do no matter what, and often that for which he is least qualified; the role he will play in society will be determined, not by chance, which in reality does not exist,²³ but by that which gives the illusion of chance, namely the entanglement of all manner of accidental circumstances; and that which will intervene least of all will be precisely the sole factor that ought to count in such a case, we mean the differences of nature that exist between men. The cause of all this disorder is the denial of these differences themselves, entailing that of every social hierarchy; and this denial, at first perhaps scarcely conscious and more practical than theoretical—for the confusion of castes preceded their complete suppression, or, in other words, men first misconceived the nature of individuals before arriving at taking no account of it at all—this denial, we say, has since been erected by the moderns into a pseudo-principle under the name of “equality.”

²³ What men call chance is simply their ignorance of causes; if one were to claim, by saying that something happens by chance, to mean that there is no cause, that would be a contradictory supposition in itself.

It would be all too easy to show that equality can exist nowhere, for the simple reason that there cannot be two beings who are at once really distinct and yet entirely alike in every respect; nor would it be less easy to bring to light all the absurd consequences that flow from this chimerical idea, in the name of which it is sought everywhere to impose a complete uniformity, for example by distributing to all an identical instruction, as though all were equally apt to understand the same things, and as though, in order to make them understand, the same methods were suitable for all without distinction. One may moreover ask whether it be not rather a question of “learning” than of truly “understanding,” that is to say whether memory is not substituted for intelligence in the wholly verbal and “bookish” conception of present-day teaching, wherein nothing is aimed at save the accumulation of rudimentary and heterogeneous notions, and wherein quality is entirely sacrificed to quantity, as happens everywhere in the modern world for reasons that we shall explain more fully later: it is always dispersion in multiplicity.

There would be much to say, in this connection, concerning the evils of “compulsory instruction”; but this is not the place to insist upon it, and, in order not to depart from the framework we have set ourselves, we must be content to note in passing this special consequence of “egalitarian” theories, as one among those elements of disorder that are today too numerous for anyone even to pretend to enumerate them without omitting some.

Naturally, when we find ourselves confronted with an idea such as that of "equality," or that of "progress," or the other "secular dogmas" which almost all our contemporaries accept blindly, and of which most began to assume explicit formulation in the course of the eighteenth century, it is impossible for us to admit that such notions arose spontaneously. They are, in sum, veritable "suggestions," in the strictest sense of that word, which moreover could produce their effect only within a milieu already prepared to receive them; they did not create out of nothing the state of mind that characterizes the modern epoch, but they have largely contributed to sustain it and to develop it to a point that it would doubtless not have reached without them. Were these suggestions to vanish, the general mentality would be very near to changing its orientation; this is why they are so carefully maintained by all who have some interest in preserving disorder, if not in aggravating it further, and also why, in a time when it is pretended that everything must be submitted to discussion, they are the only things that one never permits oneself to discuss.

It is moreover difficult to determine exactly the degree of sincerity of those who make themselves the propagators of such ideas, to know to what extent certain men come to take their own falsehoods for truth and to suggest themselves while suggesting others; and even, in a propaganda of this kind, those who play the role of dupes are often the best instruments, because they bring to it a conviction that others would have some difficulty in

simulating, and which is easily contagious. Yet, behind all this, and at least at the origin, there must be a far more conscious action, a direction that can come only from men who know perfectly well what to think of the ideas they thus set in circulation. We have spoken of "ideas," but it is only very improperly that this word can be applied here, for it is evident that there is nothing here of pure ideas, nor even of anything that belongs, near or far, to the intellectual order; they are, if one wishes, false ideas, but it would be better still to call them "pseudo-ideas," destined principally to provoke sentimental reactions, which is indeed the most effective and the easiest means for acting upon the masses. In this respect, moreover, the word has a greater importance than the notion it is supposed to represent, and most modern "idols" are in truth nothing but words; for there occurs here that singular phenomenon known as "verbalism," wherein the mere sonority of words suffices to give the illusion of thought. The influence that orators exercise upon crowds is particularly characteristic in this regard, and it is not necessary to examine it very closely in order to perceive that one is dealing with a process of suggestion entirely comparable to those of hypnotists.

But, without lingering further upon these considerations, let us return to the consequences entailed by the denial of every true hierarchy, and let us note that, in the present state of things, not only does a man fulfil his proper function only exceptionally and, as it were, by accident, whereas it is the contrary case that ought normally to be

exceptional, but it even happens that the same man is called upon to exercise successively functions wholly different, as though he could change his aptitudes at will. This may seem paradoxical in an age of excessive “specialization,” and yet it is indeed so, above all in the political order; if the competence of “specialists” is often highly illusory, and in any case limited to a very narrow domain, belief in this competence is nonetheless a fact, and one may ask how it comes about that this belief plays no role when it is a question of the careers of politicians, where the most complete incompetence is rarely an obstacle. Yet, if one reflects upon it, one readily perceives that there is nothing here to cause astonishment, and that this is in sum but a very natural result of the “democratic” conception, by virtue of which power comes from below and rests essentially upon the majority, which necessarily has as its corollary the exclusion of every true competence, because competence is always at least a relative superiority and can be only the prerogative of a minority.

Here, some explanations will not be useless in order to bring out, on the one hand, the sophisms concealed beneath the “democratic” idea, and, on the other, the links that attach this same idea to the whole ensemble of the modern mentality; it is moreover almost superfluous, given the point of view in which we place ourselves, to remark that these observations will be formulated outside all questions of parties and all political quarrels, with which we have no intention of mixing either near or far. We consider

these things in an entirely disinterested manner, as we might do for any other object of study, seeking only to render account to ourselves as clearly as possible of what lies at the bottom of all this, which is besides the necessary and sufficient condition for all the illusions that our contemporaries entertain on this subject to dissipate. Here too it is truly a matter of “suggestion,” as we said earlier concerning somewhat different but nevertheless related ideas; and, once one knows that it is only a suggestion, once one has understood how it acts, it can no longer exert itself. Against things of this kind, a somewhat deep and purely “objective” examination—so one says today in the special jargon borrowed from German philosophers—proves far more effective than all sentimental declamations and all party polemics, which prove nothing and are only the expression of simple individual preferences.

The most decisive argument against “democracy” may be summed up in a few words: the superior cannot emanate from the inferior, because the greater cannot issue from the lesser; this is of an absolutely mathematical rigor against which nothing can prevail. It is important to remark that this is precisely the same argument which, applied in another order, holds also against “materialism”; there is nothing fortuitous in this concordance, and the two things are far more closely bound together than might at first appear. It is too evident that the people cannot confer a power that it does not itself possess; true power can come only from above, and that is why, let it be said in passing, it

can be legitimized only by the sanction of something superior to the social order, that is to say, of a spiritual authority; otherwise it is no more than a counterfeit of power, a state of fact unjustifiable for lack of principle, and wherein there can be nothing but disorder and confusion. This inversion of every hierarchy begins as soon as temporal power wishes to render itself independent of spiritual authority, and then to subordinate it by pretending to make it serve political ends; there is here a first usurpation that opens the way to all the others, and one might thus show that, for example, the French monarchy, since the fourteenth century, worked itself unconsciously to prepare the Revolution that was to overthrow it. Perhaps we shall one day have occasion to develop as it deserves this point of view, which for the moment we can only indicate in a very summary fashion.

If “democracy” be defined as the government of the people by itself, this is a veritable impossibility, a thing that cannot even have a simple existence in fact, no more in our epoch than in any other; one must not allow oneself to be duped by words, and it is contradictory to admit that the same men can be at once governors and governed, because, to employ Aristotelian language, one and the same being cannot be “in act” and “in potency” at the same time and under the same respect. There is here a relation that necessarily supposes two terms in presence: there could be no governed if there were not also governors, even if they be illegitimate and without any right to power save that which

they have attributed to themselves; but the great skill of rulers in the modern world is to make the people believe that it governs itself, and the people allows itself to be persuaded all the more readily because it is flattered thereby and is moreover incapable of reflecting sufficiently to see what impossibility there is here. It is in order to create this illusion that “universal suffrage” has been invented: it is the opinion of the majority that is supposed to make the law; but what one does not perceive is that opinion is something that can very easily be directed and modified. One can always, by means of appropriate suggestions, provoke in it currents moving in this or that determined sense; we no longer know who spoke of “manufacturing opinion,” and the expression is entirely just, though it must be added that it is not always the apparent rulers who in reality have at their disposal the means necessary to obtain this result. This last remark perhaps gives the reason why the incompetence of the most “prominent” politicians seems to have only a very relative importance; but, as it is not our purpose here to dismantle the workings of what one might call the “governing machine,” we shall confine ourselves to noting that this very incompetence offers the advantage of maintaining the illusion of which we have just spoken. It is only under these conditions, indeed, that such politicians can appear as the emanation of the majority, being thus its image; for the majority, upon whatever subject it may be called to give its opinion, is always constituted by the incompetent, whose

number is incomparably greater than that of the men capable of pronouncing in full knowledge of the case.

This brings us immediately to say wherein the idea that the majority must make the law is essentially erroneous; for, even if this idea, by the force of things, is above all theoretical and cannot correspond to an effective reality, there remains nevertheless to explain how it has been able to implant itself in the modern mind, what tendencies of that mind it corresponds to and satisfies at least in appearance. The most visible defect is precisely that which we indicated a moment ago: the opinion of the majority can only be the expression of incompetence, whether this result from lack of intelligence or from pure and simple ignorance. One might introduce here certain observations of “collective psychology,” and recall in particular that fairly well-known fact that, in a crowd, the ensemble of the mental reactions produced between the individuals composing it results in the formation of a sort of resultant that is not even at the level of the average, but at that of the lowest elements. One might also remark, on the other hand, how certain modern philosophers have wished to transport into the intellectual order the “democratic” theory that makes the opinion of the majority prevail, by making of what they call “universal consent” a supposed “criterion of truth.” Even supposing that there were indeed a question upon which all men were agreed, such agreement would prove nothing by itself; but, moreover, if this unanimity really existed—which is all the more doubtful in that there are always many men who have

no opinion upon any given question and who have never even posed it to themselves—it would in any case be impossible to ascertain it in fact, so that what is invoked in favor of an opinion and as a sign of its truth reduces itself to being only the consent of the greater number, and that within a milieu necessarily very limited in space and in time. In this domain it appears still more clearly that the theory lacks foundation, because it is easier here to withdraw oneself from the influence of sentiment, which, on the contrary, almost inevitably intervenes when it is a question of the political domain; and it is this influence that is one of the principal obstacles to the understanding of certain things, even among those who would otherwise possess an intellectual capacity more than sufficient to attain such understanding without difficulty. Emotional impulses impede reflection, and it is one of the most vulgar devices of politics to profit from this incompatibility.

But let us go more deeply into the question: what exactly is this law of the greater number that modern governments invoke and from which they claim to draw their sole justification? It is quite simply the law of matter and of brute force, the very law by virtue of which a mass, carried along by its weight, crushes everything that lies in its path. Here precisely is the point of junction between the “democratic” conception and “materialism,” and it is also what makes this same conception so closely bound to the present mentality. It is the complete inversion of the normal order, since it is the proclamation of the supremacy of

multiplicity as such, a supremacy that in fact exists only in the material world;²⁴ on the contrary, in the spiritual world, and more simply still in the universal order, it is unity that is at the summit of the hierarchy, for it is the principle from which all multiplicity²⁵ proceeds. But, when the principle is denied or lost from sight, there remains only pure multiplicity, which identifies itself with matter itself.

Moreover, the allusion we have just made to weight implies more than a simple comparison, for weight effectively represents, in the domain of physical forces in the most ordinary sense of that word, the descending and compressive tendency that brings the being to an ever narrower limitation, and that at the same time proceeds in the direction of multiplicity, figured here by an ever greater density;²⁶ and this tendency is precisely that which marks the direction in which human activity has developed since the beginning of the modern epoch. Furthermore, it must

²⁴ From one order of reality to another, the analogy, here as in all similar cases, applies strictly in the opposite direction.

²⁵ One only needs to read Saint Thomas Aquinas to see that "*numerus stat ex parte materiae*".

²⁶ This tendency is what Hindu doctrine calls *tamas*, which it equates with ignorance and darkness. It should be noted that, as we said earlier regarding the application of analogy, the compression or condensation in question is the opposite of the concentration considered in the spiritual or intellectual order, so that, however strange this may seem at first, it is in reality correlated with division and dispersion in multiplicity. The same is true, moreover, of the uniformity achieved from below, at the lowest level, according to the "egalitarian" conception, which is the extreme opposite of the superior and fundamental unity.

be remarked that matter, by its power both of division and of limitation, is what scholastic doctrine calls the “principle of individuation,” and this links the considerations we are now expounding with what we said earlier concerning individualism: this same tendency of which we have just spoken is also, one might say, the “individualizing” tendency, that according to which there is effected what the Judeo-Christian tradition designates as the “fall” of beings that have separated themselves from the original unity. Multiplicity considered apart from its principle, and which thus can no longer be brought back to unity, is, in the social order, the collectivity conceived as being simply the arithmetic sum of the individuals composing it, and which in effect is nothing but that from the moment it is no longer attached to any principle superior to individuals; and the law of the collectivity, under this aspect, is indeed that law of the greater number upon which the “democratic” idea is founded.

Here we must pause for a moment in order to dispel a possible confusion: in speaking of modern individualism, we have considered almost exclusively its manifestations in the intellectual order; it might therefore be supposed that, so far as the social order is concerned, the case is altogether different. Indeed, if one were to take the word “individualism” in its narrowest acceptance, one might be tempted to oppose the collectivity to the individual, and to imagine that such facts as the increasingly invasive rôle of

the State and the growing complexity of social institutions mark a tendency contrary to individualism.

In reality this is not so; for the collectivity, being nothing other than the sum of individuals, cannot be opposed to them, any more than can the State itself when conceived in the modern manner, that is to say as the simple representation of the mass, in which no superior principle is reflected; and it is precisely in the negation of every supra-individual principle that individualism truly consists, such as we have defined it. Thus, if there are in the social domain conflicts between various tendencies that all alike belong to the modern spirit, these conflicts are not between individualism and something else, but merely between the multiple varieties of which individualism itself is susceptible; and it is easy to see that, in the absence of any principle capable of truly unifying multiplicity, such conflicts must be more numerous and more serious in our time than ever before, for whoever says individualism says necessarily division; and this division, together with the chaotic state it engenders, is the fatal consequence of a civilization wholly material, since matter itself is properly the root of division and multiplicity.

This being said, we must still insist upon an immediate consequence of the “democratic” idea, namely the negation of the elite understood in its only legitimate sense; it is not without reason that “democracy” stands opposed to “aristocracy,” the latter word designating precisely, at least when taken in its etymological sense, the

power of the elite. The elite, as it were by definition, can only be the small number; and its power — or rather its authority, which proceeds solely from its intellectual superiority—has nothing in common with the numerical force upon which “democracy” rests, whose essential character is to sacrifice the minority to the majority, and thereby also, as we have said above, quality to quantity, thus the elite to the mass.

Accordingly, the directing rôle of a true elite, and even its very existence—for it necessarily fulfils this rôle from the moment that it exists—are radically incompatible with “democracy,” which is intimately bound up with the “egalitarian” conception, that is to say with the negation of all hierarchy: the very basis of the “democratic” idea is that any individual whatsoever is the equal of any other, because they are numerically equal, although they can never be equal save in that purely numerical sense. A true elite, as we have already said, can only be intellectual; this is why “democracy” can establish itself only where pure intellectuality no longer exists, which is indeed the case in the modern world.

Yet, since equality is impossible in fact, and since it is practically impossible to suppress all difference between men, despite every effort at leveling, there arises, through a curious illogicality, the invention of false elites, moreover multiple, which claim to substitute themselves for the one real elite; and these false elites are founded upon the consideration of whatsoever superiorities, eminently relative

and contingent, and always of a purely material order. This is easily perceived by observing that the social distinction that counts most in the present state of affairs is that which is founded upon wealth, that is to say upon a superiority wholly external and of an exclusively quantitative order, in short the only one that is compatible with “democracy,” because it proceeds from the same point of view. We may add, moreover, that even those who now set themselves up as adversaries of this state of things, introducing no principle of a higher order, are incapable of effectively remedying such disorder, if indeed they do not risk aggravating it still further by going always farther in the same direction; the struggle is merely between varieties of “democracy,” accentuating more or less the “egalitarian” tendency, just as it is, as we have said, between varieties of individualism, which in truth comes to exactly the same thing.

These few reflections appear sufficient to characterize the social state of the contemporary world, and at the same time to show that, in this domain no less than in all others, there can be but one means of escape from chaos: the restoration of intellectuality and, by consequence, the reconstitution of an elite, which at present must be regarded as nonexistent in the West, for one cannot give this name to a few isolated and incoherent elements which represent, as it were, only undeveloped possibilities.

Indeed, these elements possess in general no more than tendencies or aspirations that incline them doubtless to

react against the modern spirit, but without their influence being able to exercise itself in an effective manner; what they lack is true knowledge, those traditional data that cannot be improvised, and for which an intelligence left to itself, especially in circumstances so unfavorable in every respect, can substitute only very imperfectly and in a very limited measure. Thus there are only scattered efforts, which often go astray for want of principles and doctrinal direction: one might say that the modern world defends itself by its own dispersion, from which even its adversaries do not succeed in freeing themselves.

It will remain so so long as these latter persist in keeping to the “profane” ground, where the modern spirit has an evident advantage, since that is its proper and exclusive domain; and, besides, if they keep to it, this is because that spirit still exercises over them, despite all, a very strong hold. This is why so many people, though animated by an unquestionable good will, are incapable of understanding that one must necessarily begin from principles, and persist in dissipating their forces in this or that relative domain, social or otherwise, where nothing real or durable can be accomplished under such conditions.

The true elite, on the contrary, would have no need to intervene directly in these domains nor to mingle in outward action; it would direct all by an influence imperceptible to the vulgar, and all the more profound in proportion as it were less apparent. If one reflects upon the power of the suggestions of which we spoke above, which

yet presuppose no true intellectuality, one may conjecture what would be, with stronger reason, the power of such an influence as this, exercised in a manner still more hidden by reason of its very nature, and taking its source in pure intellectuality—a power which moreover, far from being diminished by the division inherent in multiplicity and by the weakness that belongs to all that is false or illusory, would on the contrary be intensified by concentration in principial unity and would identify itself with the very force of truth.

-VII- A MATERIAL CIVILIZATION

FROM ALL THAT PRECEDES, it seems to us already to follow with sufficient clarity that the Orientals are fully justified when they reproach modern Western civilization with being no more than a civilization wholly material: it is indeed in this sense that it has developed exclusively, and, from whatever point of view it be considered, one is always confronted with consequences more or less direct of this materialization. Yet we must still complete what we have said in this respect, and first of all explain ourselves concerning the different senses in which a word such as “materialism” may be taken; for, if we employ it to characterize the contemporary world, certain persons, who do not in the least believe themselves to be “materialists” while laying claim to being very “modern,” will not fail to protest and to persuade themselves that this amounts to a veritable calumny; a clarification is therefore required in order to forestall every equivocation that might arise on this point.

It is sufficiently significant that the very word “materialism” dates only from the eighteenth century; it was invented by Berkeley, who employed it to designate every theory that admits the real existence of matter; it scarcely

needs to be said that this is not what is here in question, where that existence is in no wise at issue. A little later the same word assumed a more restricted sense, that which it has retained ever since: it came to characterize a conception according to which nothing exists other than matter and that which proceeds from it; and one must note the novelty of such a conception, the fact that it is essentially a product of the modern spirit and therefore corresponds, at least in part, to the tendencies that are proper to it.²⁷

But it is above all in another acceptation, much wider and yet perfectly definite, that we here intend to speak of "materialism": what this word then represents is an entire state of mind, of which the conception we have just defined is but one manifestation among many others, and which in itself is independent of every philosophical theory. This state of mind is that which consists in according, more or less consciously, the preponderance to things of the material order and to the preoccupations that relate thereto, whether these preoccupations still retain a certain speculative appearance or whether they be purely practical; and it can scarcely be seriously disputed that such indeed is the mentality of the immense majority of our contemporaries.

²⁷ Prior to the 18th century, there were "mechanistic" theories, from Greek atomism to Cartesian physics; but "mechanism" and "materialism" should not be confused, despite certain affinities that may have created a kind of de facto solidarity between the two since the emergence of "materialism" proper.

All the “profane” science that has developed in the course of the last centuries is nothing but the study of the sensible world; it is enclosed therein exclusively, and its methods are applicable only to this single domain; yet these methods are proclaimed “scientific” to the exclusion of all others, which amounts to denying every science that does not relate to material things. Among those who think thus, and even among those who have specially devoted themselves to the sciences in question, there are nevertheless many who would refuse to declare themselves “materialists” or to adhere to the philosophical theory that bears that name; there are even some who willingly make a profession of religious faith whose sincerity is not doubtful; but their “scientific” attitude differs little from that of avowed materialists. The question has often been debated, from the religious point of view, whether modern science ought to be denounced as atheistic or as materialistic, and most often it has been badly posed; it is certain enough that this science does not expressly profess either atheism or materialism, that it confines itself to ignoring, by deliberate choice, certain things without pronouncing upon them by a formal negation as such or such philosophers do; one can therefore speak, in its regard, only of a materialism in fact, of what we might willingly call a practical materialism; but the evil is perhaps the more grave for being the more profound and the more widespread. A philosophical attitude may be something very superficial, even among “professional” philosophers; moreover, there are minds that would recoil

before negation, yet accommodate themselves to a complete indifference; and this latter is what is most formidable, for, in order to deny a thing, one must still think of it, however little, whereas here one comes to think of it in no manner whatsoever.

When one sees a science exclusively material present itself as the only possible science, when men are habituated to admit as an indisputable truth that there can be no valid knowledge outside it, when all the education they receive tends to inculcate in them the superstition of this science—which is properly “scientism”—how could such men fail to be practically materialists, that is to say, to have all their preoccupations turned toward matter?

For the moderns, nothing seems to exist outside what can be seen and touched, or at least, even if they admit theoretically that something else may exist, they hasten to declare it not only unknown but “unknowable,” which dispenses them from concerning themselves with it. If there are nevertheless some who seek to form some idea of an “other world,” as they appeal for this only to the imagination, they represent it on the model of the terrestrial world and transport into it all the conditions of existence that belong to this one, including space and time, even a sort of “corporeity”; we have elsewhere shown, in spiritist conceptions, particularly striking examples of this kind of grossly materialized representation; but, if that be an extreme case, where this character is exaggerated to the point of caricature, it would be an error to believe that spiritism

and the sects more or less akin to it have the monopoly of such things. More generally, moreover, the intervention of the imagination in domains where it can yield nothing, and which ought normally to be forbidden to it, is a fact that clearly shows the incapacity of modern Westerners to rise above the sensible; many know not how to distinguish between “conceiving” and “imagining,” and certain philosophers, such as Kant, go so far as to declare “inconceivable” or “unthinkable” all that is not susceptible of representation. Thus all that is called “spiritualism” or “idealism” is most often but a sort of transposed materialism; this is true not only of what we have designated under the name of “neo-spiritualism,” but also of philosophical spiritualism itself, which yet considers itself the opposite of materialism. In truth, spiritualism and materialism, understood in the philosophical sense, cannot be comprehended one without the other: they are simply the two halves of Cartesian dualism, whose radical separation has been transformed into a sort of antagonism; and since then all philosophy oscillates between these two terms without being able to pass beyond them. Spiritualism, despite its name, has nothing in common with spirituality; its debate with materialism can leave entirely indifferent those who place themselves at a superior point of view and who see that these contraries are, at bottom, very near to being mere equivalents, whose pretended opposition, on many points, is reduced to a vulgar dispute of words.

The moderns, in general, conceive no science other than that of things which are measured, counted, and weighed—that is to say, in sum, material things, for it is only to these that the quantitative point of view can be applied; and the pretension to reduce quality to quantity is very characteristic of modern science. One has come, in this sense, to believe that there is no science properly so called where measurement cannot be introduced, and that there are no scientific laws except those which express quantitative relations; the “mechanism” of Descartes marked the beginning of this tendency, which has done nothing but become accentuated since then, in spite of the failure of Cartesian physics, for it is linked not to a particular theory but to a general conception of scientific knowledge. One would today apply measurement even in the psychological domain, which escapes it nevertheless by its very nature; one ends by no longer understanding that the possibility of measurement rests only on a property inherent in matter, namely its indefinite divisibility, unless one supposes that this property extends to all that exists, which amounts to materializing all things. Matter, we have already said, is principle of division and pure multiplicity; the predominance accorded to the quantitative point of view, which, as we have shown previously, is found again even in the social domain, is therefore indeed materialism in the sense we indicated above, although it is not necessarily linked to philosophical materialism, which it in fact preceded in the development of the tendencies of the

modern spirit. We shall not insist upon what is illegitimate in wishing to reduce quality to quantity, nor upon the insufficiency of all attempts at explanation that attach themselves more or less to the “mechanistic” type; that is not our present purpose, and we shall merely note, in this regard, that even in the sensible order a science of this kind has but little relation to reality, whose most considerable part necessarily escapes it.

In connection with “reality,” we are led to mention another fact, liable to pass unnoticed by many, yet very worthy of remark as a sign of the state of mind of which we speak: namely that this name, in current usage, is reserved exclusively for sensible reality alone. As language is the expression of the mentality of a people and of an epoch, it must be concluded from this that, for those who speak thus, all that does not fall under the senses is “unreal,” that is to say illusory or even altogether nonexistent; they may not be clearly conscious of it, yet this negative conviction is nonetheless within them, and, if they affirm the contrary, one may be sure—though they themselves are unaware of it—that such affirmation corresponds in them only to something far more exterior, if indeed it be not purely verbal. If one is tempted to believe that we exaggerate, one need only seek to see, for example, to what the pretended religious convictions of many people are reduced: a few notions learned by heart in a wholly scholastic and mechanical fashion, which they have in no wise assimilated, upon which they have never reflected in the least, but which

they keep in their memory and repeat on occasion because they form part of a certain formalism, of a conventional attitude which is all they can understand under the name of religion. We have already spoken above of this “minimizing” of religion, of which the “verbalism” in question represents one of the last degrees; it explains why so-called “believers,” as regards practical materialism, yield in nothing to the “unbelievers”; we shall return to this again, but first we must conclude the considerations that concern the materialist character of modern science, for this is a question that must be envisaged under different aspects.

We must also recall, although we have already indicated it, that the modern sciences have not the character of disinterested knowledge, and that, even for those who believe in their speculative value, this is scarcely more than a mask beneath which are concealed entirely practical preoccupations, but which allows the illusion of a false intellectuality to be preserved. Descartes himself, in constituting his physics, thought above all of deriving from it a mechanics, a medicine, and a morality; and, with the diffusion of Anglo-Saxon empiricism, the matter went much further still; moreover, what gives science its prestige in the eyes of the general public is almost exclusively the practical results it makes possible, because here again it is a question of things that can be seen and touched. We have said that “pragmatism” represents the outcome of all modern philosophy and its final degree of abasement; but there exists also, and for a longer time, outside philosophy, a

diffuse and unsystematized “pragmatism,” which stands to the other as practical materialism stands to theoretical materialism, and which is confounded with what the vulgar call “common sense.” This almost instinctive utilitarianism is moreover inseparable from the materialist tendency: “common sense” consists in not exceeding the terrestrial horizon, as well as in not concerning oneself with anything that has no immediate practical interest; it is for it above all that the sensible world alone is “real,” and that there is no knowledge that does not come from the senses; for it also, this restricted knowledge has value only insofar as it permits the satisfaction of material needs, and sometimes of a certain sentimentalism—for it must be said plainly, at the risk of shocking contemporary “moralism,” that sentiment in reality lies very near to matter. In all this there remains no place for intelligence, save insofar as it consents to enslave itself to the realization of practical ends, to become no more than a simple instrument subject to the exigencies of the lower and corporeal part of the human individual, or, according to a singular expression of Bergson, “a tool for making tools”; and what constitutes “pragmatism” in all its forms is a total indifference with regard to truth.

Under such conditions, industry is no longer merely an application of science—an application from which science, in itself, ought to remain wholly independent; it becomes, as it were, the very reason for science’s existence and its justification, so that here again the normal relations are inverted. That to which the modern world has applied

all its forces, even when it has imagined itself to be cultivating science in its own fashion, is in reality nothing other than the development of industry and of “mechanism”; and, in seeking thus to dominate matter and bend it to their use, men have succeeded only in making themselves its slaves, as we said at the outset: not only have they limited their intellectual ambitions—if that word may still be employed in such a case—to the invention and construction of machines, but they have ended by becoming truly machines themselves.

Indeed, “specialization,” so extolled by certain sociologists under the name of the “division of labour,” has not imposed itself only upon the learned, but also upon technicians and even upon workers, and for these latter every intelligent work is thereby rendered impossible; very different from the artisans of former times, they are now no more than the servants of the machines, they make, so to speak, one body with them; they must incessantly repeat, in a wholly mechanical fashion, certain determined movements, always the same and always accomplished in the same way, in order to avoid the least loss of time; such, at least, is the demand of those American methods which are regarded as representing the highest degree of “progress.” In truth, it is solely a matter of producing as much as possible; little heed is given to quality, quantity alone counts; we return once more to the same observation we have already made in other domains: modern civilization is indeed what

may be called a quantitative civilization, which is but another way of saying that it is a material civilization.

If one would be yet more convinced of this truth, one need only observe the immense role played today, in the life of peoples as in that of individuals, by elements of the economic order: industry, commerce, finance; it seems that these alone matter, which accords with the fact already noted that the sole social distinction which has subsisted is that founded upon material wealth. It appears that financial power dominates all politics, that commercial competition exercises a preponderant influence upon relations between peoples; perhaps this is only an appearance, and these things are here less true causes than simple means of action; but the choice of such means clearly indicates the character of the epoch to which they are suited. Moreover, our contemporaries are persuaded that economic circumstances are almost the sole factors of historical events, and they even imagine that it has always been so; in this direction one has gone so far as to invent a theory which would explain everything exclusively thereby, and which has received the significant name of "historical materialism." Here again one may see the effect of one of those suggestions to which we alluded above, suggestions which act all the more effectively in that they correspond to the tendencies of the general mentality; and the effect of this suggestion is that economic means end by determining almost everything that occurs in the social domain.

Doubtless, the mass has always been led in one fashion or another, and one might say that its historical role consists above all in allowing itself to be led, because it represents only a passive element, a “matter” in the Aristotelian sense; but today it suffices, in order to lead it, to dispose of purely material means—this time in the ordinary sense of the word—which shows clearly enough the degree of abasement of our epoch; and, at the same time, this mass is made to believe that it is not led, that it acts spontaneously and governs itself, and the fact that it believes this allows one to perceive how far its unintelligence may go.

While we are speaking of economic factors, we may also take the occasion to point out a too widespread illusion on this subject, which consists in imagining that relations established on the ground of commercial exchange may serve to bring about a rapprochement and understanding between peoples, whereas in reality they produce exactly the contrary effect. Matter, as we have said many times, is essentially multiplicity and division, therefore a source of struggles and conflicts; thus, whether it be a question of peoples or of individuals, the economic domain is, and cannot but be, that of rivalries of interest. In particular, the West has nothing to hope from industry—nor from modern science, which is inseparable from it—as a ground of understanding with the East; if the Orientals come to accept this industry as an unfortunate necessity, and moreover a transitory one, for them it can never be anything more, it will only be as a weapon enabling them to resist Western

encroachment and to safeguard their own existence. It is important that this be clearly understood: the Orientals who resign themselves to envisage economic competition with the West, despite the repugnance they feel for this kind of activity, can do so only with a single intention, that of ridding themselves of a foreign domination which rests solely upon brute force, upon the material power that industry precisely places at its disposal; violence calls forth violence, but it must be recognized that it is certainly not the Orientals who have sought the struggle upon this ground.

Apart from the question of relations between East and West, it is easy to observe that one of the most notable consequences of industrial development is the incessant perfection of engines of war and the increase of their destructive power in formidable proportions. This alone ought to suffice to annihilate the “pacifist” dreams of certain admirers of modern “progress”; but dreamers and “idealists” are incorrigible, and their naïveté seems to know no bounds. The “humanitarianism” so much in vogue certainly does not deserve to be taken seriously; yet it is strange to hear so much talk of the end of wars at an epoch when they cause more ravages than they have ever done, not only because of the multiplication of means of destruction, but also because, instead of being carried on between relatively small armies composed solely of professional soldiers, they hurl against one another all individuals indiscriminately, including those least qualified to fulfill such a function. Here again is a striking example of modern confusion, and it

is truly prodigious, for whoever reflects upon it, that one has come to regard as altogether natural a "levée en masse" or a "general mobilization," that the idea of an "armed nation" should have imposed itself upon almost all minds, with very rare exceptions. One may also see here an effect of the belief in the sole force of number: it is in conformity with the quantitative character of modern civilization to set in motion enormous masses of combatants; and at the same time "egalitarianism" finds its account therein, as it does also in institutions such as "compulsory instruction" and "universal suffrage."

Let us add that these generalized wars have been rendered possible only by another specifically modern phenomenon, namely the constitution of "nationalities," a consequence on the one hand of the destruction of the feudal régime, and on the other of the simultaneous rupture of the superior unity of medieval "Christendom"; and, without lingering upon considerations that would carry us too far, let us also note, as an aggravating circumstance, the disregard of a spiritual authority which alone could normally exercise an effective arbitration, because it is, by its very nature, above all conflicts of the political order. The negation of spiritual authority is again practical materialism; and even those who claim to recognize such an authority in principle deny it in fact all real influence and all power of intervention in the social domain, exactly in the same way that they establish a watertight partition between religion and the ordinary preoccupations of their existence; whether

it be a question of public life or of private life, it is indeed the same state of mind that affirms itself in both cases.

Granting that material development may have certain advantages, moreover from a very relative point of view, one may, when considering consequences such as those we have just indicated, ask whether these advantages are not greatly outweighed by the inconveniences. We do not even speak of all that has been sacrificed to this exclusive development and which was incomparably more valuable; we do not speak of the higher knowledges forgotten, of intellectuality destroyed, of spirituality disappeared; we take modern civilization simply in itself, and we say that, if one were to set in parallel the advantages and the inconveniences of what it has produced, the result would very likely be negative. The inventions that are now multiplying with ever-increasing rapidity are the more dangerous in that they set in motion forces whose true nature is entirely unknown to those very men who employ them; and this ignorance is the best proof of the nullity of modern science from the standpoint of explanatory value, therefore as knowledge, even limited to the physical domain alone; at the same time, the fact that practical applications are in no way hindered thereby shows that this science is indeed oriented solely in an interested direction, that industry is the only real end of all its researches. As the danger of inventions—even of those not expressly destined to play a harmful role for humanity, and which nevertheless cause so many catastrophes, without speaking of the unsuspected disturbances they provoke in

the terrestrial milieu—as this danger, we say, will doubtless only increase in proportions difficult to determine, it is permissible to think, without too much improbability, as we indicated already above, that it may perhaps be by this very means that the modern world will come to destroy itself, if it is incapable of halting in this path while there is yet time.

But it does not suffice, in what concerns modern inventions, to make the reservations imposed by their dangerous aspect; one must go further: are not the pretended “benefits” of what it has become customary to call “progress”—and which one might indeed consent to designate thus if care were taken to specify clearly that it is only a wholly material progress—are not these much-vaunted “benefits” in large part illusory? The men of our epoch claim thereby to increase their “well-being”; for our part, we think that the end they thus propose to themselves, even if it were really attained, is not worth the efforts devoted to it; moreover, it seems to us highly contestable that it is attained. First of all, account would have to be taken of the fact that all men have neither the same tastes nor the same needs, that there are still, despite everything, some who would wish to escape modern agitation, the madness of speed, and who can no longer do so; will one dare maintain that, for these, it is a “benefit” to impose upon them what is most contrary to their nature? One will say that such men are few today, and one will believe oneself authorized thereby to treat them as a negligible quantity; here as in the political domain, the

majority arrogates to itself the right to crush minorities, which, in its eyes, have evidently no right to exist, since their very existence runs counter to the “egalitarian” mania for uniformity. But, if one considers the whole of humanity instead of limiting oneself to the Western world, does not the question change its aspect: will not the majority of a moment ago become a minority? Thus it is no longer the same argument that is invoked in this case, and, by a strange contradiction, it is in the name of their “superiority” that these “egalitarians” would impose their civilization upon the rest of the world and go to disturb peoples who asked nothing of them; and, since this “superiority” exists only from the material point of view, it is quite natural that it should impose itself by the most brutal means. Let there be no mistake: if the general public admits in good faith these pretexts of “civilization,” there are some for whom it is only a simple “moralistic” hypocrisy, a mask for the spirit of conquest and for economic interests; but what a singular epoch is this in which so many men allow themselves to be persuaded that one makes a people happy by enslaving it, by taking from it what it possesses most precious, namely its own civilization, by obliging it to adopt manners and institutions made for another race, and by constraining it to the most painful labours in order to make it acquire things of the most perfect uselessness to it!

For it is thus: the modern West cannot tolerate that men should prefer to work less and be content with little in order to live; since quantity alone counts, and since what

does not fall under the senses is moreover held to be nonexistent, it is admitted that he who does not agitate himself and does not produce materially can only be a “lazy man”; without even speaking in this regard of the judgments commonly passed upon Eastern peoples, one need only see how the contemplative orders are judged, and that even in supposedly religious circles. In such a world there is no longer any place for intelligence nor for all that is purely interior, for these are things which are neither seen nor touched, neither counted nor weighed; there is place only for outward action under all its forms, including those most devoid of all significance. Nor should one be surprised that the Anglo-Saxon mania for “sport” gains ground each day: the ideal of this world is the “human animal” who has developed his muscular strength to the maximum; its heroes are athletes, though they be brutes; it is these who arouse popular enthusiasm, it is for their exploits that the crowds grow passionate; a world in which such things are seen has indeed fallen very low and seems already very near its end.

However, let us place ourselves for a moment at the standpoint of those who set their ideal in material “well-being,” and who, for that reason, rejoice in every improvement that modern “progress” has brought to existence; are they indeed certain that they are not deceived? Is it true that men are happier today than formerly because they possess swifter means of communication or other things of that sort, because their life is more agitated and more complex? It seems to us that the contrary is the case:

disequilibrium cannot be the condition of a true happiness; moreover, the more needs a man has, the more he runs the risk of lacking something, and consequently of being unhappy. Modern civilization aims at multiplying artificial needs, and, as we have already said, it will always create more needs than it can satisfy; for once one has entered upon this path it is very difficult to halt, and there is indeed no reason for halting at any determined point. Men could feel no suffering at being deprived of things that did not exist and of which they had never conceived; now, on the contrary, they inevitably suffer if such things fail them, since they have grown accustomed to regard them as necessary, and since in fact they have truly become necessary to them. Thus they strive, by every means, to acquire whatever may procure for them all material satisfactions, the only ones they are capable of appreciating: the sole concern is to “make money,” because that is what permits the acquisition of things; and the more one has, the more one wishes to have still, because one continually discovers new needs; and this passion becomes the single end of the whole of life. Hence the ferocious competition that certain “evolutionists” have raised to the dignity of a scientific law under the name of the “struggle for life,” the logical consequence of which is that the strongest, in the most narrowly material sense of the word, alone have the right to exist. Hence also the envy and even the hatred of which those who possess wealth are the object on the part of those who are deprived of it; how could men to whom “egalitarian” theories have been

preached fail to revolt when they behold around them inequality under the form that must be most sensible to them, because it belongs to the grossest order? If modern civilization were one day to collapse beneath the pressure of the disordered appetites it has awakened in the mass, one would have to be singularly blind not to see therein the just punishment of its fundamental vice, or, to speak without any moralizing phraseology, the recoil of its own action in the very domain where it has been exercised. It is said in the Gospel: "He who takes the sword shall perish by the sword"; he who unleashes the brutal forces of matter will perish crushed by those same forces, of which he is no longer master once he has imprudently set them in motion, and which he cannot boast of holding back indefinitely in their fatal course. Forces of nature or forces of human masses, or both together, it matters little; it is always the laws of matter that enter into play and inexorably break him who believed he could dominate them without himself rising above matter. And the Gospel says again: "Every house divided against itself shall fall"; this word also applies exactly to the modern world, with its material civilization, which by its very nature can only everywhere engender struggle and division. The conclusion is too easy to draw, and there is no need to appeal to other considerations in order to predict for this world, without fear of error, a tragic end, unless a radical change, amounting to a veritable reversal, should intervene at no distant date.

We know well that some will reproach us, when speaking of the materialism of modern civilization as we have just done, with neglecting certain elements that seem at least to constitute an attenuation of this materialism; and indeed, were such elements absent, it is highly probable that this civilization would already have perished miserably. We in no way contest the existence of such elements, but one must not be deluded on this point: on the one hand, we cannot include among them all that, in the philosophical domain, presents itself under labels such as “spiritualism” and “idealism,” nor all that, in contemporary tendencies, is merely “moralism” and “sentimentalism”; we have already explained ourselves sufficiently on this subject, and we shall simply recall that these are, for us, points of view no less “profane” than that of theoretical or practical materialism, and that in reality they are far less removed from it than they appear. On the other hand, if some remnants of true spirituality still subsist, it is despite the modern spirit and against it that they have endured up to the present. These remnants of spirituality, for all that properly concerns the West, can only be found in the religious order; but we have already said how diminished religion is today, how narrow and mediocre a conception even its own adherents form of it, and to what degree intellectuality—which is one with true spirituality—has been eliminated from it. In such conditions, if certain possibilities still remain, it is scarcely except in a latent state, and at present their effective rôle is reduced to very little. None the less one must admire the

vitality of a religious tradition which, even thus reabsorbed into a sort of virtuality, persists in spite of all the efforts that have been made for several centuries to stifle and annihilate it; and, if one knew how to reflect, one would see that in this resistance there is something that implies a power “non-human.” Yet once more, this tradition does not belong to the modern world, it is not one of its constitutive elements; it is the very contrary of its tendencies and its aspirations. This must be said plainly, and one must not seek vain conciliations: between the religious spirit, in the true sense of the word, and the modern spirit, there can be only antagonism; every compromise can only weaken the former and profit the latter, whose hostility will not thereby be disarmed, for it can desire only the complete destruction of all that in humanity reflects a reality superior to humanity. It is said that the modern West is Christian, but this is an error: the modern spirit is anti-Christian, because it is essentially anti-religious; and it is anti-religious because, more generally still, it is anti-traditional; therein lies its proper character, that which makes it to be what it is. Certainly, something of Christianity has passed even into the anti-Christian civilization of our time, whose most “advanced” representatives, as they say in their special language, cannot prevent themselves from having undergone, and from still undergoing, involuntarily and perhaps unconsciously, a certain Christian influence, at least indirectly; it is so because a rupture with the past, however radical it may be, can never be absolutely complete so as to suppress all continuity. We

shall go further still, and say that whatever there may be of value in the modern world has come to it from Christianity, or at least through Christianity, which brought with it the whole heritage of anterior traditions, preserved it living so far as the state of the West allowed, and still bears within itself the latent possibilities thereof; but who today, even among those who affirm themselves Christian, still has the effective consciousness of these possibilities? Where are there, even within Catholicism, men who know the profound sense of the doctrine they outwardly profess, who do not content themselves with “believing” in a more or less superficial way and more through sentiment than through intelligence, but who truly “know” the truth of the religious tradition they regard as theirs? We would fain have proof that at least a few such men exist, for that would be, for the West, the greatest and perhaps the sole hope of salvation; yet we must confess that hitherto we have encountered none. Must it be supposed that, like certain sages of the East, they remain hidden in some retreat almost inaccessible, or must one renounce definitively this last hope? The West was Christian in the Middle Ages, but it is so no longer; if it be said that it may yet become so again, none wishes this more than we, and that it may come to pass at a day nearer than all that we see around us would suggest; but let there be no mistake: on that day, the modern world will have ceased to be.

-VIII- WESTERN ENCROACHMENT

MODERN DISORDER, WE HAVE SAID, took its rise in the West, and until recent years it had there remained strictly localized; but now a fact presents itself whose gravity must not be dissimulated: this disorder is spreading everywhere and seems even to be gaining the East. Certainly, the Western encroachment is not altogether recent, but hitherto it had been confined to a domination more or less brutal, exercised over other peoples, and whose effects were limited to the political and economic domain; in spite of all the efforts of a propaganda assuming manifold forms, the Eastern spirit remained impenetrable to every deviation, and the ancient traditional civilizations subsisted intact. Today, on the contrary, there are Orientals who have become more or less completely “Westernized,” who have abandoned their tradition in order to adopt all the aberrations of the modern spirit; and these misguided elements, thanks to the teaching of European and American universities, become in their own countries a cause of disturbance and agitation.

It would not be fitting, moreover, at least for the present, to exaggerate their importance: in the West one readily imagines that these noisy individualities, though few in number, represent the contemporary East, whereas in

reality their action is neither very extensive nor very profound. This illusion is easily explained, for the true Orientals are not known, and besides they do not in the least seek to make themselves known; the “modernists,” if they may so be called, are the only ones who show themselves outwardly, who speak, write, and bestir themselves in every way. None the less it remains true that this anti-traditional movement may gain ground, and one must envisage every eventuality, even the most unfavorable; already the traditional spirit seems, as it were, to withdraw into itself, the centres in which it is integrally preserved becoming more and more closed and difficult of access; and this generalization of disorder corresponds indeed to what must take place in the final phase of the *Kali-Yuga*.

Let us declare it very clearly: the modern spirit being a purely Western thing, those who are affected by it, even though they be Orientals by birth, must, as regards their mentality, be regarded as Westerners; for every Oriental idea is wholly foreign to them, and their ignorance of traditional doctrines is the sole excuse for their hostility. What may appear rather singular and even contradictory is that these same men, who make themselves auxiliaries of “Occidentalism” from the intellectual point of view— or more exactly against all true intellectuality—sometimes appear as its adversaries in the political domain; yet at bottom there is nothing here at which one should be astonished. It is they who strive to institute various “nationalisms” in the East, and every “nationalism” is

necessarily opposed to the traditional spirit; if they wish to combat foreign domination, it is by the very methods of the West, in the same manner as the various Western peoples struggle among themselves; and perhaps therein lies their very *raison d'être*. For if matters have come to such a point that the employment of such methods has become inevitable, their application can only be the work of elements that have broken every bond with tradition; it may therefore be that these elements will be thus used provisionally, and afterwards eliminated like the Westerners themselves. It would indeed be logical enough that the ideas which the latter have spread should turn against them, for they can only be factors of division and ruin; it is by this that modern civilization will perish in one manner or another. It matters little whether this be through dissensions among the Westerners themselves, dissensions between nations or between social classes, or, as some maintain, through the attacks of "Westernized" Orientals, or again as the result of a cataclysm provoked by the "progress of science"; in every case, the Western world runs dangers only through its own fault and through what proceeds from itself.

The sole question that arises is this: will the East have to undergo, through the fact of the modern spirit, only a passing and superficial crisis, or will the West drag the whole of humanity down in its fall? It would be difficult at present to give an answer founded upon indubitable observations; the two opposing spirits now both exist in the East, and the spiritual force, inherent in tradition and

unrecognized by its adversaries, may triumph over material force when the latter shall have played out its role, and cause it to vanish as light dissipates darkness. We shall even say that it must triumph sooner or later; but it may be that, before arriving at that point, there will be a period of complete obscurity. The traditional spirit cannot die, because in its essence it is superior to death and to change; but it may withdraw entirely from the outward world, and then it will be truly the “end of a world.” According to all that we have said, the realization of this eventuality in a relatively near future would have nothing improbable about it; and in the confusion which, issuing from the West, is at present spreading to the East, one might see the “beginning of the end,” the precursory sign of the moment when, according to the Hindu tradition, the sacred doctrine must be enclosed in its entirety within a conch, to emerge from it intact at the dawn of the new world.

But let us once more leave aside anticipations and consider only present events: what is incontestable is that the West invades everything. Its action first exercised itself in the material domain, the one immediately within its reach, whether by violent conquest or by commerce and the monopolizing of the resources of all peoples; but now matters go still further. The Westerners, ever animated by that need for proselytism which is so peculiarly theirs, have succeeded in causing their anti-traditional and materialist spirit to penetrate, to a certain degree, among others; and whereas the first form of invasion in the end affected only

bodies, this one poisons intelligences and slays spirituality. The former moreover prepared the latter and rendered it possible, so that in the last analysis it is only by brute force that the West has succeeded in imposing itself everywhere, and it could not be otherwise, for therein resides the sole real superiority of its civilization, so inferior from every other point of view. Western encroachment is the encroachment of materialism in all its forms, and it can be nothing else; all the more or less hypocritical disguises, all the “moralistic” pretexts, all the “humanitarian” declamations, all the artifices of a propaganda which knows how, when occasion demands, to make itself insinuating in order the better to attain its end of destruction, can avail nothing against this truth, which can be contested only by the naïve or by those who have some interest in this work truly “satanic,” in the most rigorous sense of the word.²⁸

A strange thing indeed: at the very moment when the West is invading everything, there are those who choose this occasion to denounce, as a danger filling them with alarm, a supposed penetration of Eastern ideas into that same West; what new aberration is this? Despite our desire to confine ourselves to considerations of a general order, we cannot refrain from saying here at least a few words

²⁸ *Satan* in Hebrew means “the adversary,” that is, the one who overturns all things and takes them in a way backwards; it is the spirit of negation and subversion, which is identified with the downward or “inferiorizing” tendency, “infernal” in the etymological sense, the very one followed by beings in this process of materialization according to which the entire development of modern civilization takes place.

concerning a *Defence of the West* recently published by M. Henri Massis, which constitutes one of the most characteristic manifestations of this state of mind. This book abounds in confusions and even in contradictions, and it shows once again how little capable most of those who would react against modern disorder are of doing so in a truly effective manner, since they do not even know very clearly what it is that they have to combat.

The author sometimes protests that he has not wished to attack the true East; and if he had in fact confined himself to a critique of the “pseudo-oriental” fancies—that is to say, of those purely Western theories disseminated under deceptive labels, and which are but one among many products of the present disequilibrium—we could only give him our full approval, the more so since we ourselves, long before him, had pointed out both the real danger of such things and their intellectual nullity. But unfortunately he then feels the need to attribute to the East conceptions scarcely better than those; and to do so he relies upon citations borrowed from certain more or less “official” orientalist, in which Eastern doctrines are, as commonly happens, distorted to the point of caricature. What would he say if someone employed the same procedure with regard to Christianity and claimed to judge it on the basis of the works of university “hypercritics”? It is precisely this that he does for the doctrines of India and China, with the aggravating circumstance that the Westerners whose testimony he invokes possess not the least direct knowledge

of these doctrines, whereas those among their colleagues who occupy themselves with Christianity must at least know it to some extent, even if their hostility toward all that is religious prevents them from truly understanding it.

Moreover, we must say on this occasion that we have sometimes found it difficult to persuade Orientals that the expositions of this or that orientalist proceeded from sheer misunderstanding and not from a conscious and deliberate bias, so strongly does one there perceive that same hostility which is inherent in the anti-traditional spirit; and we would willingly ask M. Massis whether he thinks it very skilful to attack tradition among others when one wishes to restore it in one's own country. We speak of skilfulness because, at bottom, the whole discussion is by him carried onto a political ground; for ourselves, who place ourselves at an entirely different point of view, that of pure intellectuality, the only question that arises is one of truth. But this point of view is doubtless too elevated and too serene for polemicists to find satisfaction in it, and we even doubt whether, as polemicists, concern for truth can occupy any very considerable place in their preoccupations.²⁹

²⁹ We know that Mr. Massis is aware of our works, but he carefully avoids making the slightest allusion to them, because they would contradict his thesis; this approach is, at the very least, lacking in candor. Moreover, we believe we can only be pleased with this silence, which prevents us from seeing matters that, by their very nature, should remain above all discussion, dragged into unpleasant polemics; there is always something distressing in the spectacle of "profane" incomprehension,

M. Massis attacks what he calls "Oriental propagandists," an expression that contains within itself a contradiction, for the spirit of propaganda, as we have often said, is a thing wholly Western; and this alone already suffices to indicate clearly that some misunderstanding is present here. In fact, among the propagandists he has in view, two groups may be distinguished, the first being composed of pure Westerners; it would be truly comical, were it not a sign of the most deplorable ignorance of the realities of the East, to see Germans and Russians counted among the representatives of the Oriental spirit. The author makes, in regard to them, observations of which some are very just; but why does he not show them plainly for what they really are? To this first group we may further add the Anglo-Saxon "theosophists" and all the founders of other sects of the same order, whose Oriental terminology is but a mask intended to impose upon the naïve and the ill-informed, and which covers only ideas as foreign to the East as they are dear to the modern West. These latter are moreover more dangerous than mere philosophers, by reason of their pretensions to an "esoterism" which they possess no more than the others, but which they simulate fraudulently in order to attract those minds that seek something other than "profane" speculations and that, amidst the present chaos, do not know where to turn; we are

although the truth of "sacred doctrine" is certainly, in itself, too lofty to suffer its attacks.

somewhat surprised that M. Massis says almost nothing of them.

As for the second group, we find there some of those Westernized Orientals of whom we spoke earlier, who, being as ignorant as the former of genuine Oriental ideas, would be quite incapable of spreading them in the West, even if they had such an intention. Besides, the aim they truly pursue is the very opposite, since it is to destroy these same ideas in the East, while at the same time presenting to Westerners their modernized Orient, accommodated to the theories taught them in Europe or America. True agents of the most pernicious of all Western propagandas, that which directly attacks the intelligence, they constitute a danger for the East and not for the West, of which they are only a reflection. As for the real Orientals, M. Massis does not mention a single one, and he would indeed have been hard pressed to do so, for he certainly knows none; the impossibility in which he found himself of citing the name of an Oriental who was not Westernized ought to have given him pause and made him understand that "Oriental propagandists" are purely nonexistent.

Moreover, although this obliges us to speak of ourselves, which is little in our habits, we must declare formally this: to our knowledge, no one has expounded authentic Oriental ideas in the West except ourselves; and we have always done so exactly as any Oriental would have done who had been led there by circumstances, that is to say, without the least intention of "propaganda" or

“popularization,” and solely for those who are capable of understanding doctrines as they are, without their being denatured under the pretext of rendering them accessible. We shall add that, despite the decadence of Western intellectuality, those who understand are still less rare than we should have supposed, though they are obviously but a small minority.

Such an undertaking is certainly not of the sort imagined by M. Massis—we dare not say for the needs of his cause, though the political character of his book might justify such an expression. Let us say, to be as benevolent as possible, that he imagines them because his mind is troubled by the fear awakened in him by the presentiment of a more or less imminent ruin of Western civilization; and let us regret that he has not clearly perceived where the true causes lie that might bring about this ruin, although at times he shows a just severity toward certain aspects of the modern world. This indeed is what produces the continual wavering of his thesis: on the one hand, he does not know exactly which adversaries he ought to combat; on the other, his “traditionalism” leaves him greatly ignorant of what is the very essence of tradition, which he visibly confounds with a sort of politico-religious conservatism of the most external order.

We say that M. Massis’s mind is troubled by fear; perhaps the best proof of this is the extraordinary, even altogether inconceivable, attitude he attributes to his so-called “Oriental propagandists.” These, he supposes,

would be animated by a fierce hatred toward the West, and it would be in order to harm it that they would strive to communicate to it their own doctrines, that is to say, to make it the gift of what they themselves hold most precious, of what in some way constitutes the very substance of their spirit. Faced with all that is contradictory in such a hypothesis, one cannot but feel a genuine astonishment: the whole painfully constructed thesis collapses instantly, and it seems the author has not even perceived it, for we do not wish to suppose that he was conscious of so great an improbability and simply counted on the lack of discernment of his readers to make them accept it.

There is no need for prolonged or profound reflection to realize that, if there are people who hate the West so much, the first thing they must do is jealously to guard their doctrines for themselves, and that all their efforts must tend to forbid Westerners access to them; this indeed is a reproach that has sometimes been addressed to the Orientals, with more appearance of reason. The truth, however, is quite different: the authentic representatives of traditional doctrines feel hatred toward no one, and their reserve has but one cause, namely that they judge it perfectly useless to expound certain truths to those incapable of understanding them; yet they have never refused to share them with those—whatever their origin—who possess the required “qualifications.” Is it their fault if, among these latter, there are very few Westerners? And on the other hand, if the Oriental masses finally become truly hostile to

Westerners, after having long regarded them with indifference, who is responsible? Is it that elite which, wholly given to intellectual contemplation, keeps resolutely apart from external agitation, or is it rather the Westerners themselves, who have done all that was needed to render their presence odious and intolerable? It suffices that the question be posed thus, as it ought to be, for anyone to answer it immediately; and if the Orientals, who have shown until now an incredible patience, should at last wish to be masters in their own house, who could sincerely think of blaming them?

It is true that, when certain passions intervene, the same things may, according to circumstances, be judged in very different ways, even in contrary ways. Thus, when resistance to a foreign invasion is the act of a Western people, it is called “patriotism” and is worthy of all praise; when it is the act of an Oriental people, it is called “fanaticism” or “xenophobia” and deserves only hatred or contempt. Moreover, is it not in the name of “Right,” of “Liberty,” of “Justice,” and of “Civilization” that Europeans pretend everywhere to impose their domination, and to forbid any man to live and think otherwise than they themselves live and think? One must admit that “moralism” is truly an admirable thing—unless one prefers simply to conclude, as we do, that, save for exceptions all the more honorable because they are rarer, there remain in the West scarcely more than two kinds of people, equally uninteresting: the naïve who allow themselves to be taken in by these grand

words and believe in their “civilizing mission,” unconscious of the materialist barbarism in which they are plunged, and the clever who exploit this state of mind for the satisfaction of their instincts of violence and greed. In any case, what is certain is that the Orientals threaten no one and scarcely think of invading the West in any manner; for the moment they have quite enough to do defending themselves against European oppression, which risks reaching even into their spirit; and it is at least curious to see the aggressors pose as victims.

This clarification was necessary, for there are certain things that must be said; but we should reproach ourselves for insisting further, the thesis of the “defenders of the West” being truly too fragile and inconsistent. If, moreover, we have departed for a moment from the reserve we usually observe with regard to individuals in order to cite M. Henri Massis, it is chiefly because he represents on this occasion a certain portion of the contemporary mentality, of which we must also take account in this study of the state of the modern world. How could this “traditionalism” of an inferior order, narrowly limited and lacking understanding—perhaps even somewhat artificial—really and effectively oppose a spirit whose prejudices it shares in so many respects? On both sides there is, with little difference, the same ignorance of true principles; the same resolve to deny all that surpasses a certain horizon; the same incapacity to understand the existence of different

civilizations; the same superstition of Greco-Latin "classicism."

This insufficient reaction interests us only insofar as it marks a certain dissatisfaction with the present state among some of our contemporaries; of this same dissatisfaction there are moreover other manifestations that might go further if they were rightly directed. For the moment, however, all this remains very chaotic, and it is still very difficult to say what will emerge from it. Yet a few anticipations on this subject may perhaps not be entirely useless; and, since they are closely bound to the destiny of the present world, they may at the same time serve as conclusions to this study, insofar as it is permitted to draw conclusions without giving "profane" ignorance too easy an occasion for attack, by imprudently developing considerations that could not be justified by ordinary means. We are not of those who think that everything may be said indiscriminately, at least when one passes from pure doctrine to its applications; certain reserves then impose themselves, and questions of opportunity inevitably arise. But these legitimate and even indispensable reserves have nothing in common with certain puerile fears that are but the effect of an ignorance comparable to that of the man who, according to the Hindu proverbial expression, "takes a rope for a serpent."

Whether one wishes it or not, what must be said will be said as circumstances require; neither the interested efforts of some nor the unconscious hostility of others will

be able to prevent it, any more than, on the other hand, the impatience of those who, carried away by the febrile haste of the modern world, would wish to know everything at once can cause certain things to become outwardly known sooner than is fitting. Yet these latter may at least console themselves in thinking that the accelerated course of events will doubtless give them satisfaction soon enough; may they then have no cause to regret having insufficiently prepared themselves to receive a knowledge that they so often seek with more enthusiasm than true discernment.

-IX- SOME CONCLUSIONS

WE HAVE WISHED ABOVE ALL to show here how the application of traditional data permits the resolution, in the most immediate manner, of the questions that present themselves today, to explain the present state of terrestrial humanity, and at the same time to judge according to truth, and not according to conventional rules or sentimental preferences, all that properly constitutes modern civilization. We have had, moreover, no pretension to exhaust the subject, to treat it in all its details, or to develop completely all its aspects without neglecting any; the principles from which we constantly draw our inspiration oblige us, besides, to present views that are essentially synthetic and not analytical like those of “profane” knowledge. Yet these views, precisely because they are synthetic, go much further in the direction of a veritable explanation than any analysis whatsoever, which in reality possesses scarcely more than a merely descriptive value. In any case, we think we have said enough to allow those who are capable of understanding to draw for themselves, from what we have expounded, at least a part of the consequences implicitly contained therein; and they must be well persuaded that such labour will profit them far more than a

reading that left no place for reflection and meditation, for which, on the contrary, we have wished only to furnish a suitable point of departure, a sufficient support whereby one may rise above the vain multitude of individual opinions.

There remain a few words to be said concerning what might be called the practical bearing of such a study; this bearing we might have neglected or disregarded had we confined ourselves to pure metaphysical doctrine, in relation to which every application is but contingent and accidental; here, however, it is precisely of applications that there is question. These, moreover, have, apart from every practical standpoint, a twofold *raison d'être*: they are the legitimate consequences of principles, the normal development of a doctrine which, being one and universal, must embrace all orders of reality without exception; and at the same time they are also, for some at least, a preparatory means for rising to a higher knowledge, as we have explained in speaking of "sacred science." Yet, beyond this, it is not forbidden, when one is in the domain of applications, to consider them also in themselves and in their proper value, provided that one is never led thereby to lose sight of their attachment to principles; this danger is very real, since it is from this that the degeneration arose which gave birth to "profane science," but it does not exist for those who know that all derives from and depends entirely upon pure intellectuality, and that what does not consciously proceed from it can be only illusory. As we have often repeated, everything must

begin with knowledge; and that which seems most remote from the practical order proves nevertheless the most efficacious within that very order, for it is that without which, there as elsewhere, nothing can be accomplished that is truly valid, that is anything other than a vain and superficial agitation.

Thus, to return more particularly to the question that now occupies us, we may say that, if all men understood what the modern world really is, it would cease at once to exist, for its existence, like that of ignorance and of all that is limitation, is purely negative: it subsists only by the negation of traditional and supra-human truth. Such a change would thus occur without any catastrophe, which seems almost impossible by any other path; are we then wrong in affirming that such knowledge is capable of truly incalculable practical consequences? Yet, on the other hand, it appears unfortunately very difficult to admit that all could attain to this knowledge, from which the majority of men are certainly further removed than ever before; it is true that this is in no way necessary, for it suffices that there be an elite small in number but strongly constituted, capable of giving direction to the mass, which would obey its suggestions without even having the least idea of its existence or of its means of action. Is the effective constitution of such an elite still possible in the West?

We have no intention of returning to all that we have already had occasion to set forth elsewhere concerning the role of the intellectual elite in the various circumstances

that may be envisaged as possible in a more or less imminent future. We shall therefore confine ourselves to saying this: whatever be the manner in which the change is accomplished that constitutes what may be called the passage from one world to another—whether, moreover, it be a question of cycles more or less extended—this change, even if it bear the appearance of a sudden rupture, never implies an absolute discontinuity, for there is a causal chain that links all cycles one to another. The elite of which we speak, if it succeeded in forming while there is still time, could prepare the change in such a way that it would occur under the most favourable conditions, and that the disturbance which will inevitably accompany it might in some sense be reduced to a minimum; but even if it were not so, it would always have another task, more important still, that of contributing to the conservation of what must survive the present world and serve for the edification of the world to come. It is evident that one must not wait until the descent is finished to prepare the ascent, once one knows that this ascent will necessarily take place, even if one cannot avoid that the descent first culminate in some cataclysm; and thus, in every case, the work accomplished will not be lost: it cannot be so as regards the benefits the elite will draw from it for itself, but neither will it be so as regards its ulterior results for the whole of humanity.

Now, matters must be envisaged thus: the elite still exists in the Oriental civilizations, and, even if it be admitted that it is more and more reduced before the modern

invasion, it will nevertheless subsist until the end, because it is necessary that it be so, in order to guard the deposit of the tradition which cannot perish, and to assure the transmission of all that must be preserved. In the West, by contrast, the elite no longer exists at present; one may therefore ask whether it will be reconstituted there before the end of our epoch, that is to say, whether the Western world, despite its deviation, will have a share in this conservation and this transmission. If it be not so, the consequence will be that its civilization must perish in its entirety, because there will remain in it no element utilisable for the future, because every trace of the traditional spirit will have disappeared from it. The question thus posed may have only a very secondary importance as regards the final result; it nevertheless presents a certain interest from a relative point of view, which we must take into consideration once we consent to reckon with the particular conditions of the period in which we live. In principle, one might be content to remark that this Western world is, despite everything, a part of the whole from which it seems to have detached itself since the beginning of modern times, and that, in the ultimate integration of the cycle, all the parts must in some fashion be found again; but this does not necessarily imply a prior restoration of the Western tradition, for this may be preserved only in the state of permanent possibility in its very source, apart from the special form it assumed at some determined moment. We offer this, moreover, only as an indication, for to understand

it fully one would have to introduce the consideration of the relations between the primordial tradition and the subordinate traditions, which we cannot think of doing here. This would be the most unfavourable case for the Western world taken in itself, and its present state may cause one to fear that this case is indeed the one that will be realized; nevertheless, we have said that there are some signs that permit one to think that all hope of a better solution is not yet definitively lost.

There now exists in the West a greater number than is believed of men who begin to become conscious of what their civilization lacks; if they are reduced to vague aspirations and to researches too often sterile, if they even at times go wholly astray, it is because they lack real data, for which nothing can serve as a substitute, and because there is no organization capable of furnishing them with the doctrinal direction that is necessary. We are not speaking here, of course, of those who have been able to find this direction in the Oriental traditions and who are thus, intellectually, outside the Western world; these, who in any case can represent only an exceptional case, could in no way be an integral part of a Western elite. They are in reality a prolongation of the Oriental elites, which might become a link between these and the Western elite on the day when the latter should have succeeded in constituting itself; but it can, so to speak by definition, be constituted only by an initiative properly Western, and therein lies the whole difficulty. This initiative is possible only in two ways: either

the West will find the means within itself, by a direct return to its own tradition, a return that would be as a spontaneous awakening of latent possibilities; or certain Western elements will accomplish this work of restoration with the aid of a certain knowledge of Oriental doctrines, a knowledge which, however, cannot be absolutely immediate for them, since they must remain Western, but which may be obtained through a sort of second-degree influence, exercised through intermediaries such as those to whom we alluded earlier. The first of these two hypotheses is highly improbable, for it implies the existence in the West of at least one point where the traditional spirit would have been preserved integrally, and we have said that, despite certain affirmations, this existence appears to us extremely doubtful; it is therefore the second hypothesis that must be examined more closely.

In this case, there would be advantage, although it is not of absolute necessity, if the elite in formation could take a point of support in a Western organization already possessing an effective existence; now it seems indeed that there remains in the West only one organization that possesses a traditional character and that preserves a doctrine capable of furnishing to the work in question a suitable base: this is the Catholic Church. It would suffice to restore to its doctrine, without changing anything in the religious form under which it presents itself outwardly, the profound sense that it truly possesses in itself, but of which its present representatives appear no longer to be conscious,

any more than of its essential unity with the other traditional forms; the two things, moreover, are inseparable from one another. This would be the realization of Catholicism in the true sense of the word, which, etymologically, expresses the idea of “universality,” something too often forgotten by those who would make of it only the exclusive denomination of a special and purely Western form, without any effective link with the other traditions. One may say that, in the present state of things, Catholicism has only a virtual existence, since one does not truly find in it the consciousness of universality; but it remains nonetheless true that the existence of an organization bearing such a name indicates a possible base for a restoration of the traditional spirit in its complete acceptance, and this all the more so because, in the Middle Ages, it already served as the support of that spirit in the Western world. There would therefore be, in sum, only a reconstitution of what existed before the modern deviation, with the adaptations necessary to the conditions of another epoch; and if some are astonished or protest against such an idea, it is because they themselves, unbeknown to them and perhaps against their will, are imbued with the modern spirit to the point of having completely lost the sense of a tradition of which they retain only the shell. It would be important to know whether the formalism of the “letter,” which is still one of the varieties of the “materialism” understood above, has definitively stifled spirituality, or whether the latter is only temporarily obscured and may yet

awaken within the very bosom of the existing organization; but it is only the course of events that will make this known. It may be, moreover, that these events themselves will sooner or later impose upon the leaders of the Catholic Church, as a kind of ineluctable necessity, that whose importance they would not directly comprehend from the point of view of pure intellectuality; it would assuredly be regrettable if, in order to give them cause for reflection, circumstances so contingent as those belonging to the political domain, considered apart from every superior principle, were required; yet one must admit that the occasion for the development of latent possibilities must be furnished to each by the means that are most immediately within the reach of his present comprehension. Therefore we shall say this: in the face of an aggravation of disorder that becomes more and more general, there is reason to call for the union of all the spiritual forces that still exercise an action in the external world, in the West as well as in the East; and on the Western side we see none other than the Catholic Church. If this could thereby enter into contact with the representatives of the Oriental traditions, we should have only to rejoice in this first result, which might precisely be the point of departure of what we have in view; for it would doubtless soon be perceived that a merely external and “diplomatic” understanding would be illusory and could not have the desired consequences, so that one would be compelled to come to that with which one ought normally to have begun, namely to envisage agreement on

principles, an agreement whose necessary and sufficient condition would be that the representatives of the West should again become truly conscious of these principles, as those of the East always remain.

The true understanding, let us repeat once more, can be accomplished only from above and from within, consequently in the domain that may indifferently be called intellectual or spiritual, for, for us, these two words have in the end exactly the same signification; then, and proceeding from there, the understanding would necessarily be established also in all the other domains, just as, when a principle is posited, there remains only to deduce, or rather to “explicate,” all the consequences that are implied therein. There can be here but a single obstacle: it is Western proselytism, which cannot resolve to admit that one must sometimes have “allies” who are not “subjects”; or, to speak more exactly, it is the defect of understanding of which this proselytism is only one of the effects. Will this obstacle be overcome? If it were not, the elite, in order to constitute itself, would have to count only upon the effort of those who were qualified by their intellectual capacity, apart from every defined milieu, and also, of course, upon the support of the East; its work would thereby be rendered more difficult and its action could be exercised only at a longer term, since it would have to create for itself all its instruments instead of finding them already prepared as in the other case; but we do not think in the least that these difficulties, however great they may be, are of a nature to

prevent that which must be accomplished from being accomplished in one way or another.

We deem it opportune, therefore, to declare further this: that there are already, within the Western world, certain signs of a movement which, though still imprecise, may and indeed must normally lead to the reconstitution of an intellectual elite, unless some cataclysm should intervene too swiftly to permit its full development. It scarcely needs to be said that the Church, as regards its future rôle, would have every advantage in, as it were, anticipating such a movement, rather than allowing it to be accomplished without her and being constrained to follow it belatedly in order to maintain an influence that might otherwise escape her; one need not adopt a point of view particularly elevated or difficult of access in order to understand that, in sum, it is she who would reap the greatest benefit from an attitude which, far from demanding the least doctrinal compromise on her part, would on the contrary have the effect of freeing her from every infiltration of the modern spirit, while moreover modifying nothing outwardly. It would be somewhat paradoxical to see integral Catholicism realized without the cooperation of the Catholic Church, which might then find herself under the singular obligation of accepting to be defended, against assaults more terrible than any she has ever undergone, by men whom her leaders, or at least those whom they permit to speak in their name, had first sought to discredit by casting upon them the most ill-founded suspicions; and for our part we should regret that it were so.

But if matters are not to reach that point, it is high time that those upon whom their position confers the gravest responsibilities should act in full knowledge of the case, and no longer permit that attempts capable of bearing consequences of the highest importance should risk being arrested by the incomprehension or the ill will of certain more or less subordinate individualities—something already witnessed, and which shows once more to what extent disorder reigns everywhere today.

We foresee clearly enough that no gratitude will be shown us for these warnings, which we give in complete independence and in an entirely disinterested manner; little does this concern us, and we shall not the less continue, when it is necessary and in whatever form we judge most suited to the circumstances, to say what must be said. What we now state is but the summary of the conclusions to which we have been led by certain quite recent “experiences,” undertaken, it goes without saying, upon a purely intellectual plane; we have not, for the moment at least, to enter into details which, besides, would be of little interest in themselves; but we may affirm that there is not a single word in what precedes that we have written without mature reflection. Let it be well understood that it would be perfectly useless to seek to oppose to this the philosophical quibbles we choose to ignore; we speak seriously of serious things, we have no time to lose in verbal discussions that hold no interest for us, and we intend to remain entirely foreign to all polemic, to every quarrel of school or of party,

just as we absolutely refuse to allow any Western label whatsoever to be applied to us, for there is none that suits us; whether this please or displease certain persons, it is so, and nothing could make us change our attitude in this respect.

We must now also make a warning heard by those who, through their aptitude for a higher understanding, if not yet by the degree of knowledge they have effectively attained, seem destined to become elements of the possible elite. There is no doubt that the modern spirit, truly “diabolical” in every sense of the word, strives by every means to prevent these elements, today isolated and dispersed, from acquiring the cohesion necessary to exercise a real action upon the general mentality; it is therefore for those who have already, more or less completely, become conscious of the end toward which their efforts must tend, not to allow themselves to be diverted from it by whatever difficulties may arise before them. For those who have not yet reached the point from which an infallible direction no longer permits deviation from the true path, the gravest aberrations are always to be feared; the greatest prudence is therefore necessary, and we would even willingly say that it must be carried to the point of mistrust, for the “adversary,” until that point, is not definitively vanquished, and knows how to assume the most diverse and sometimes the most unexpected forms.

It happens that those who believe they have escaped modern “materialism” are recaptured by things which, while

appearing opposed to it, are in reality of the same order; and, given the turn of mind of Westerners, they must in this regard be warned more particularly against the attraction exercised upon them by phenomena more or less extraordinary. From this source arise in large part all the errors of “neo-spiritualism,” and it is to be foreseen that this danger will yet increase, for the obscure forces that sustain the present disorder find therein one of their most powerful means of action. It is even probable that we are no longer very far from the time to which that evangelical prediction already recalled elsewhere refers: “There shall arise false Christs and false prophets, and shall show great signs and wonders, insomuch that, if it were possible, they shall deceive the very elect.” The “elect” are, as the word indicates, those who form part of the elite understood in the fullness of its true sense; and let us add on this occasion that it is for this reason we hold to the term “elite,” despite the abuse made of it in the “profane” world. These, by virtue of the interior “realization” to which they have attained, can no longer be seduced; but it is not so with those who, having within themselves only possibilities of knowledge, are properly no more than the “called”; and this is why the Gospel says that there are “many called, but few chosen.”

We are entering a time in which it will become particularly difficult to “distinguish the tares from the wheat,” truly to accomplish what theologians call the “discernment of spirits,” by reason of the disordered manifestations that will only intensify and multiply, and

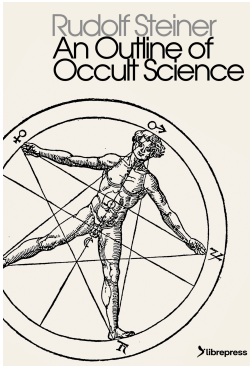
also by reason of the lack of true knowledge among those whose normal function should be to guide others, and who today are too often but “blind guides.” It will then be seen whether, in such circumstances, dialectical subtleties are of any utility, and whether a “philosophy,” even the best possible, will suffice to arrest the unleashing of the “infernal powers”; this too is an illusion against which certain must defend themselves, for there are too many who, ignorant of what pure intellectuality is, imagine that a merely philosophical knowledge—which, even in the most favorable case, is scarcely more than a shadow of true knowledge—is capable of remedying everything and of rectifying the contemporary mentality, just as there are others who believe they find in modern science itself a means of rising to superior truths, whereas that science is founded precisely upon the negation of those truths. All these illusions are so many causes of error; much effort is thus expended in pure loss, and it is in this way that many of those who sincerely wish to react against the modern spirit are reduced to impotence, because, not having known how to find the essential principles without which all action is absolutely vain, they have allowed themselves to be drawn into blind alleys from which they can no longer escape.

Those who succeed in overcoming all these obstacles and in triumphing over the hostility of an environment opposed to all spirituality will doubtless be few; but, once again, it is not number that matters, for we are here in a domain whose laws are altogether other than those of

matter. There is therefore no cause for despair; and even if there were no hope of attaining any sensible result before the modern world sinks into some catastrophe, that would still not be a valid reason for failing to undertake a work whose real scope extends far beyond the present epoch. Those who might be tempted to yield to discouragement must remember that nothing accomplished in this order can ever be lost, that disorder, error, and obscurity can prevail only in appearance and in a wholly momentary manner, that all partial and transitory disequilibria must necessarily concur in the great total equilibrium, and that nothing can finally prevail against the power of truth; their device should be that once adopted by certain initiatic organizations of the West: *Vincit omnia Veritas*.

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